

## FIRST WORDS

Acts 2:42 And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in prayers.

Luke records how new converts who had been recorded to have been saved earlier on in verse 41, about 3000 of them, continued steadfastly in the Apostle's doctrine, breaking of bread, fellowship and prayers. This means there is usually a follow up to very salvation decision or should we say salvation experience of a new convert.

That is the reason and basis for this material.

We believe that every Christian soul winner should be armed properly and equipped to help the new convert grow in the knowledge of God's word and spiritual activities that will enhance his spiritual growth.

This has 30 days and 30 different lessons on how to go about or what to say to that new convert who is in Christ Jesus.

I believe that there cannot be enough resources in this regard as more people are being won and received into God's kingdom, there is a further need to have them well taught and established and properly strengthened by the word of God.

This book will provide that help for as many who are engaged in soul winning.

So go ahead read it, meditate upon it and share it with that new convert and we will see and achieve spiritual growth in their life in Jesus name.

I remain multidimensionally yours, Chris Olusegun Onayinka.

## INTRODUCTION

Philemon 1:4 I thank my God, making mention of thee always in my prayers, Vs 5 Hearing of thy love and faith, which thou hast toward the Lord Jesus, and toward all saints; Vs 6 That the communication of thy faith may become effectual by the acknowledging of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus.

Paul, in the above letter to Philemon, speaks about the believer's faith becoming effective when he comes to a full comprehension of who he is in Christ. This implies that, a man, upon receiving the gospel and becoming a believer, must be aware of some facts, for him to be an effective believer.

This invariably means that until the believer is made aware of these facts, he cannot be effective as a Christian.

Thus, there are things for the believer to learn which includes who he is in Christ, what he is in Christ and what he can do in Christ.

However, the believer also needs to learn about his responsibilities. The teaching (training) would be incomplete if all the believer learns are his rights in Christ but no responsibilities. The believer must know with all certainty, his rights in Christ and equally pay attention to his responsibilities.

1st Timothy 2:1 I exhort therefore, that, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men; Vs 2 For kings, and for all that are in authority; that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and honesty. Vs 3 For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour, Vs 4 Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth.

The text above shows God's will; which is for men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

Jesus Himself stated this;

Matthew 28:18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Vs 19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Vs 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Matthew captured in his gospel, Jesus' emphasis on teaching. Having preached the gospel to a man (and he responds by believing), the next thing is for him/her to be taught God's word to the end that he grows spiritually. This process of making disciples and teaching them to become students is an instruction from Jesus

The Book of Acts is replete with information detailing the accounts of the apostles after getting men saved.

Acts 2:41 Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls. Vs 42 And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in prayers.

Acts 5:41 And they departed from the presence of the council, rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer shame for his name. Vs 42 And daily in the temple, and in every house, they ceased not to teach and preach Jesus Christ.

Hence, the Great Commission never ended with preaching the gospel to the unsaved. The task is not complete until the new believer is learning God's word and he is being trained to be a student of the same.

Ephesians 4:11 And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; Vs 12 For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ:

The word "perfecting" means to equip the saints for the work of the ministry. This is achieved by discipleship and this ought to be the ultimate goal of every believer and every local church.

The process by which this is carried out is what the terminology "follow up" is about. It implies teaching and training the believer and it involves personal touch. It involves the believer functioning as the teacher to the one who just got saved or a believer who is unlearned.

As the name "follow up" implies, it is an activity that ought to be done consistently. The believer who is involved in evangelism and discipleship (and every believer should be- 2nd Corinthians 5: 18-19) would then go through the scriptures with the intent of making the convert a student of the Word.

This is the very essence of this study - for the believer who desires to walk in God's will; to have men come to the knowledge of the truth and also for the disciple (the new believer) to acknowledge every good thing which is in him in Christ- his rights and responsibilities in Christ.

In teaching the new or unlearned believer, a believer carrying out follow up must know exactly what to teach. As Paul said to Philemon, the believer is to know the good things in him, in Christ. This implies that there are facts specific that the believer must know. Hence, the believer on 'follow up', with intent for the other believer to grow, must teach the right things. The essence of this book is to provide a daily guidance on what to teach the new/unlearned believer.

## DAY 1

### WHO AM I - I AM SAVED BY HIS GRACE

Now that we are saved, it is important to know; who we are, else we will live our lives in ignorance.

Philemon 1:6 That the communication of thy faith may become effectual by the acknowledging of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus.

We ought to have a precise understanding of every good thing in us in Christ.

Hence, it is important firstly to find out what we received at salvation. This is the bedrock of Christian living.

The very foundation of the Christian life is that "I am saved by what God did in Christ".

It is important for us as believers to know how salvation came and be assured and guaranteed of the same.

Salvation is not what we did but what God did. Salvation is not what we gave but what we received.

Ephesians 2:5 Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved.) Vs 6 And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus:

Hence, salvation is what God did in Christ that we received. By what Jesus has done, we are saved through faith.

Observe,

Ephesians 2:8 For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Vs 9 Not of works, lest any man should boast.

Paul explained the fact that salvation is not of works.

For instance, if one works, he is paid salary/ wages. This is not a gift but what he has worked for. When one is given what he deserves, it is not a gift.

The term "gift of God" implies that salvation is not what we deserved as we did not work for it.

2nd Timothy 1:9 Who hath saved us, and called us with an holy calling, not according to our works, but according to his own purpose and grace, which was given us in Christ Jesus before the world began,

Titus 3:4 But after that the kindness and love of God our Saviour toward man appeared, Vs 5 Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to his mercy he saved us, by the washing of regeneration, and renewing of the Holy Ghost;

How were we saved?

We were saved by the message of the gospel;

Romans 1:16 For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ: for it is the power of God unto salvation to every one that believeth; to the Jew first, and also to the Greek.

Romans 10:8 But what saith it? The word is nigh thee, even in thy mouth, and in thy heart: that is, the word of faith, which we preach; Vs 9 That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised him from the dead, thou shalt be saved. Vs 10 For with the heart man believeth unto righteousness; and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation... Vs 17 So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

We were saved by faith in the message of the gospel that was preached to us.

Therefore, what brings salvation is what God has done in Christ. This is the foundation of our Christianity.

Observe,

Hebrews 7:24 But this man, because he continueth ever, hath an unchangeable priesthood. Vs 25 Wherefore he is able also to save them to the uttermost that come unto God by him, seeing he ever liveth to make intercession for them.

The word "uttermost" implies that what Christ did is complete and forever. Hence, Christ himself guarantees our salvation. Our salvation is not for a while but eternal.

Jude 1:24 Now unto him that is able to keep you from falling and to present you faultless before the presence of his glory with exceeding joy,

Jesus also gave an absolute status of our salvation;

John 10:28 And I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish, neither shall any man pluck them out of my hand. Vs 29 My Father, which gave them me, is greater than all; and no man is able to pluck them out of my Father's hand.

Paul buttressed this;

Romans 8:39 Nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Therefore,

Ephesians 2:5 Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved;) Vs 6 And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus:

The believer today is alive forevermore. We have an irreversible union with God. We were saved by grace through faith and that salvation is secured and guaranteed in Christ Jesus.

Confession - I am a recipient of God's grace. I am saved by his grace through faith. Christ is the assurance of my salvation.

DAY 2

WHO AM I? I AM BORN AGAIN

The Psalmist prophesied;

Psalms 102:18 This shall be written for the generation to come: and the people which shall be created shall praise the LORD.

He prophesied of a new people; a new creation.

Paul explained the fulfillment of this prophesy;

2nd Corinthians 5:17 Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.

The man who is in Christ is a new creature.

The term "new creature" implies there is a new birth different from the natural conception.

Jesus spoke of the new birth;

John 3:3 Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.

The term "born again" implies to come from above or to be produced from above.

In the later verse, he explained this;

John 3:5 Jesus answered, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.

He explained being born again as being born of water. Water here refers to Spirit. Observe that in consequent verses (verse 6, 8), emphasis was given to the spirit.

Also, the word "water" was used by John in other chapters.

John 4:13 Jesus answered and said unto her, Whosoever drinketh of this water shall thirst again: Vs 14 But whosoever drinketh of the water that I shall give him shall never thirst; but the water that I shall give him shall be in him a well of water springing up into everlasting life.

He explained water as life.

John 6:63 It is the spirit that quickeneth; the flesh profiteth nothing: the words that I speak unto you, they are spirit, and they are life.

The words "spirit" and "life" are synonymous terms.

John 7:37 In the last day, that great day of the feast, Jesus stood and cried, saying, If any man thirst, let him come unto me, and drink. Vs 38 He that believeth on me, as the scripture hath said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water. Vs 39 (But this spake he of the Spirit, which they that believe on him should receive: for the Holy Ghost was not yet given; because that Jesus was not yet glorified.)

He likened water to the spirit.

Also,

Ezekiel 36:25 Then will I sprinkle clean water upon you, and ye shall be clean: from all your filthiness, and from all your idols, will I cleanse you. Vs 26 A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh,

and I will give you an heart of flesh. Vs 27 And I will put my spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes, and ye shall keep my judgments, and do them.

Therefore, being born again implies to be born of the spirit.

Hence,

John 3:14 And as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, even so must the Son of man be lifted up: Vs 15 That whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have eternal life. Vs 16 For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.

He lets us see that whosoever believes in him when he is raised from dead will receive everlasting life which is the Spirit. Hence, new birth (being born again) is available by the resurrection of Jesus.

A man receives this by faith.

1 Peter 1:23. Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever.

Confession- I am born again. I am a new creature in Christ Jesus.

DAY 3

WHO AM I? - I AM A SON OF GOD

Now that we are saved, born again, we must see God as our Father.

Recall that being born again implies to come from or to be produced by. Hence, it will imply that parentage is involved.

1st John 3:9 Whosoever is born of God doth not commit sin; for his seed remaineth in him: and he cannot sin, because he is born of God. Vs 10 In this the children of God are manifest, and the children of the devil: whosoever doeth not righteousness is not of God, neither he that loveth not his brother.

1st John 4:4 Ye are of God, little children, and have overcome them: because greater is he that is in you, than he that is in the world.

1st John 5:1 Whosoever believeth that Jesus is the Christ is born of God: and every one that loveth him that begat loveth him also that is begotten of him.

Being born again implies that we are born of God.

James 1:17 Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and cometh down from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning, Vs 18 Of his own will begat he us with the word of truth, that we should be a kind of firstfruits of his creatures.

1 Peter 1:3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, which according to his abundant mercy hath begotten us again unto a lively hope by the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead,

Therefore, we were begotten again by God, the father of our Lord Jesus Christ. Hence, we are sons of God.

Peter spoke of our identification with Christ.

Psalms 2:7 I will declare the decree: the LORD hath said unto me, Thou art my Son; this day have I begotten thee.

Hebrews 1:5 For unto which of the angels said he at any time, Thou art my Son, this day have I begotten thee? And again, I will be to him a Father, and he shall be to me a Son?

In resurrection, Jesus is referred to as the first begotten son of God which implies that he is a model son. This implies that every other son will be just like him.

In resurrection, we identify with Christ. Who Christ is, is who we are.

Hebrews 2:10 For it became him, for whom are all things, and by whom are all things, in bringing many sons unto glory, to make the captain of their salvation perfect through sufferings.

Hebrews 2:11 For both he that sanctifieth and they who are sanctified are all of one: for which cause he is not ashamed to call them brethren,

Romans 8:29 For whom he did foreknow, he also did predestinate to be conformed to the image of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brethren.

Colossians 1:18 And he is the head of the body, the church: who is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, that in all things he might have the preeminence.

Therefore, today, we are sons of God.

John 1:12 But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on his name:

The word "son" implies one who proceeds from you.

It is important to note that service is not what makes us sons even though we are to serve as sons.

Naturally speaking, a son remains a son. He does not become more of a son because he attends to domestic chores. He is not qualified as a son because he is obedient though he should be obedient.

We are sons of God because we are identified with Christ at his resurrection. God is our father. This is the result of faith in his resurrection.

Romans 8:15 For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear; but ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father. Vs 16 The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God: Vs 17 And if children, then heirs; heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ; if so be that we suffer with him, that we may be also glorified together.

Galatians 4:6 And because ye are sons, God hath sent forth the Spirit of his Son into your hearts, crying, Abba, Father. Vs 7 Wherefore thou art no more a servant, but a son; and if a son, then an heir of God through Christ.

Sonship is our right and privilege in Christ. This is our status and it is unchangeable.

Confession - I am a son of God now. Just as Christ is, so am I.

DAY 4

WHO AM I? – I AM RIGHTEOUS IN CHRIST

Righteousness in this context will imply to be without fault, blame or guilt. It implies to have a right standing with God, that is, we can stand before God without any sense of guilt, shame or condemnation.

Romans 8:1 There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit.

The believer today has a right standing with God, free from condemnation.

Romans 8:32 He that spared not his own Son, but delivered him up for us all, how shall he not with him also freely give us all things? Vs 33 Who shall lay any thing to the charge of God's elect? It is God that justifieth. Vs 34 Who is he that condemneth? It is Christ that died, yea rather, that is risen again, who is even at the right hand of God, who also maketh intercession for us.

Rather than God condemning us, he has justified us.

How?

Romans 10:8 But what saith it? The word is nigh thee, even in thy mouth, and in thy heart: that is, the word of faith, which we preach; Vs 9 That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised him from the dead, thou shalt be saved. Vs 10 For with the heart man believeth unto righteousness; and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation.

We are made righteous by faith in what Christ has done. Hence, salvation, we were made righteous.

This is our nature in Christ.

Observe the basis of Abraham's righteousness;

Romans 4:2 For if Abraham were justified by works, he hath whereof to glory; but not before God. Vs 3 For what saith the scripture? Abraham believed God, and it was counted unto him for righteousness. Vs 4 Now to him that worketh is the reward not reckoned of grace, but of debt. Vs 5 But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness.

He was declared righteous by faith and not by his works.

Therefore,

Romans 3:19 Now we know that what things soever the law saith, it saith to them who are under the law: that every mouth may be stopped, and all the world may become guilty before God. Vs 20 Therefore by the deeds of the law there shall no flesh be justified in his sight: for by the law is the knowledge of sin. Vs 21 But now the righteousness of God without the law is manifested, being witnessed by the law and the prophets; Vs 22 Even the righteousness of God which is by faith of Jesus Christ unto all and upon all them that believe: for there is no difference: Vs 23 For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God; Vs 24 Being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in

Christ Jesus;

Righteousness is of Christ to all who believe.

It was given freely.

Righteousness, just as all Christ has done, comes by grace and received by faith. Hence, righteousness is a gift.

Romans 5:15 But not as the offence, so also is the free gift. For if through the offence of one many be dead, much more the grace of God, and the gift by grace, which is by one man, Jesus Christ, hath abounded unto many. Vs 16 And not as it was by one that sinned, so is the gift: for the judgment was by one to condemnation, but the free gift is of many offences unto justification. Vs 17 For if by one man's offence death reigned by one; much more they which receive abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness shall reign in life by one, Jesus Christ.) Vs 18 Therefore as by the offence of one judgment came upon all men to condemnation; even so by the righteousness of one the free gift came upon all men unto justification of life. Vs 19 For as by one man's disobedience many were made sinners, so by the obedience of one shall many be made righteous.

Righteousness is a gift and we have been made righteous by the obedience of Jesus.

Hence, everyone of God's children has God's righteousness. Righteousness does not come because of what we do but it comes to us because of what he did.

It does not come based on works but through Jesus.

Therefore, as believers, we need to be righteousness conscious. That is, to be conscious of the fact that we stand before God in boldness, without blame or fear of guilt.

1st Corinthians 15:34 Awake to righteousness, and sin not; for some have not the knowledge of God: I speak this to your shame.

Righteous consciousness should dominate our prayer lives and help us live above sin.

Confession - I am the Righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. Sin has no power over me. I stand boldly before the father without any sense of fear or guilt or condemnation.

DAY 5

WHAT I HAVE IN CHRIST? FORGIVENESS

Ephesians 4:32 And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

God's love is not seen just from the perspective of everyday experiences but what he did through Jesus.

God's love is shown in that he forgave our sins.

Psalms 103:2 Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits: Vs 3 Who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases;

Forgiveness of sins implies taking away of sins.

It is important for us to know this fact; that our sins have been forgiven.

Forgiveness of sins is in Christ.

Ephesians 1:7 In whom we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of his grace;

Colossians 1:13 Who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son: Vs 14 In whom we have redemption through his blood, even the forgiveness of sins:

Forgiveness of sins for the believer is what we have received and not what we seek or pray for. Just as all that God did in Christ for us, forgiveness is our right and privilege.

Acts 10:43 To him give all the prophets witness, that through his name whosoever believeth in him shall receive remission of sins.

1 John 2:1 My little children, these things write I unto you, that ye sin not. And if any man sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous: Vs 2 And he is the propitiation for our sins: and not for ours only, but also for the sins of the whole world.

1st John 2:12 I write unto you, little children, because your sins are forgiven you for his name's sake.

He explains the forgiveness of God in the past. It is what God has given to us in Christ.

Romans 8:32 He that spared not his own Son, but delivered him up for us all, how shall he not with him also freely give us all things?

Observe,

Luke 7:36 And one of the Pharisees desired him that he would eat with him. And he went into the Pharisee's house. and sat down to meat. Vs 37 And, behold, a woman in the city, which was a sinner, when she knew that Jesus sat at meat in the Pharisee's house, brought an alabaster box of ointment, Vs 38 And stood at his feet behind him weeping, and began to wash his feet with tears, and did wipe them with the hairs of her head, and kissed his feet, and anointed them with the ointment. Vs 39 Now when the Pharisee which had bidden him saw it, he spake within himself, saying, This man, if he were a prophet, would have known who and what manner of woman this is that toucheth him: for she is a sinner. Vs40 And Jesus answering said unto him, Simon, I have somewhat to say unto thee. And he saith, Master, say on. Vs 41 There was a certain creditor which had two debtors: the one owed five hundred pence, and the other fifty. Vs 42 And when they had nothing to pay, he frankly forgave them both. Tell me therefore, which of them will love him most? Vs 43 Simon answered and said, I suppose that he, to whom he forgave most. And he said unto him, Thou hast rightly judged. Vs 44 And he turned to the woman, and said unto Simon, Seest thou this woman? I entered into thine house, thou gavest me no water for my feet: but she hath washed my feet with tears, and wiped them with the hairs of her head. Vs 45 Thou gavest me no kiss: but this woman since the time I came in hath not ceased to kiss my feet. Vs 46 My head with oil thou didst not anoint: but this woman hath anointed my feet with ointment. Vs 47 Wherefore I say unto thee, Her sins, which are many, are forgiven; for she loved much: but to whom little is forgiven, the same loveth little. Vs 48 And he said unto her, Thy sins are forgiven. Vs 49 And they that sat at meat with him began to say within themselves, Who is this that forgiveth sins also? Vs 50 And he said to the woman, Thy faith hath saved thee; go in peace.

Forgiveness of sins is unconditional.

Micah 7:18 Who is a God like unto thee, that pardoneth iniquity, and passeth by the transgression of the remnant of his heritage? he retaineth not his anger for ever, because he delighteth in mercy. Vs 19 He will turn again, he will have compassion upon us; he will subdue our iniquities; and thou wilt cast all their sins into the depths of the sea.

Some human beings will forgive when you do something. God forgives us before we did it.

God's forgiveness is by grace. Hence, no action can bring about or stop forgiveness.

Observe,

Luke 24:46 And said unto them, Thus it is written, and thus it behoved Christ to suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day: Vs 47 And that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations, beginning at Jerusalem.

The word "remission" is the same word as "forgiveness" which implies to take away sins. He refers to the gospel as repentance and remission of sins.

Observe the word "repentance" as used here. It implies to change focus to the gospel. Repentance is from two words which implies to change one's mind. It is not a change of character rather it is to change one's opinion by believing the gospel. Change of character comes with spiritual growth, it is not the criteria to be saved. To be saved requires one to believe the gospel.

Note that the penalty of sin is death.

Romans 6:23 For the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

Sin has being judged.

Genesis 2:16 And the LORD God commanded the man, saying. Of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat: Vs 17 But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it: for in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die.

The judgment on sin is death. It is the death of the sinner that is the penalty of sin.

What takes away sin is not confession of sins but the sacrifice of Jesus;

Hebrews 9:27 And as it is appointed unto men once to die, but after this the judgment: Vs 28 So Christ was once offered to bear the sins of many; and unto them that look for him shall he appear the second time without sin unto salvation.

Romans 5:7 For scarcely for a righteous man will one die: yet peradventure for a good man some would even dare to die. Vs 8 But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

The death of Jesus brings forgiveness. Our response is to receive the forgiveness that Jesus has died for.

Acts 10:43 To him give all the prophets witness, that through his name whosoever believeth in him shall receive remission of sins.

Today, by faith in the gospel, we have received the forgiveness of sins.

Confession - I am forgiven because of the sacrifice of Jesus. I walk in the reality of his forgiveness of my sins.

DAY 6

WHAT I HAVE IN CHRIST? - INDWELLING OF THE SPIRIT

It is important to note that the giving of the spirit is not separate from the giving of Christ. That is, as we received Christ at salvation, we have received the spirit of God.

Acts 2:33 Therefore being by the right hand of God exalted, and having received of the Father the promise of the Holy Ghost, he hath shed forth this, which ye now see and hear.

Peter in describing the event in Acts 2 explained that the Holy spirit is given in Christ.

Recall that being born again is being born of the spirit.

John 3:3 Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God. Vs 4 Nicodemus saith unto him, How can a man be born when he is old? can he enter the second time into his mother's womb, and be born? Vs 5 Jesus answered, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God. Vs 6. That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.

Jesus spoke several times of the promise of the spirit;

John 16:7 Nevertheless I tell you the truth; It is expedient for you that I go away: for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you; but if I depart, I will send him unto you.

John 4:14 But whosoever drinketh of the water that I shall give him shall never thirst; but the water that I shall give him shall be in him a well of water springing up into everlasting life.

Recall that the word "water" was used by John to explain the spirit. Hence, the giving of the spirit is in Christ. Much more, the spirit resides in the believer.

John 14:16 And I will pray the Father, and he shall give you another Comforter, that he may abide with you for ever; Vs17 Even the Spirit of truth; whom the world cannot receive, because it seeth him not, neither knoweth him: but ye know him; for he dwelleth with you, and shall be in you.

The believer today is indwelt by the spirit of God, and it is eternal; forever.

Hence, Paul spoke of this fulfillment.

2nd Corinthians 1:21 Now he which stablisheth us with you in Christ, and hath anointed us, is God; Vs 22 Who hath also sealed us, and given the earnest of the Spirit in our hearts.

The word "seal" implies to put a mark on something. It is a mark of finality.

The word "earnest" implies a guarantee, that is, it is yours.

The spirit of God is ours and the presence in us guarantees our salvation.

Similarly,

2nd Corinthians 5:5 Now he that hath wrought us for the selfsame thing is God, who also hath given unto us the earnest of the Spirit.

He also spoke of how and when the spirit is received.

Ephesians 1:13 In whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise, Vs 14 Which is the earnest of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession, unto the praise of his glory.

Ephesians 4:30 And grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption.

At salvation, we received the spirit of God. Therefore, we do not pray or ask for the spirit of God because the spirit is ours.

Paul lets us see that if a man does not have the spirit of God, it is because he is not saved.

Romans 8:9 But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you. Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his.

The Spirit of God indwells every believer and the believer must acknowledge this fact.

1st Corinthians 3:16: Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?

1 Corinthians 6:19: What? Know ye not that your body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you, which you have of God, and ye are not your own?

The Spirit of God is IN the believer.

Confession I have the spirit of God in me forever. I walk in this reality as I benefit of the indwelling of the spirit.

DAY 7

NOW THAT YOU ARE IN CHRIST

Having seen who you are in Christ and what you have in Christ, let us examine what you can do in Christ.

What are my responsibilities as a believer?

Generally, growth is a sign of life, a proof of success in investment, the trophy of hard work.

Therefore, spiritual growth ought to be the pursuit of every believer. As believers, it is a choice that we have to make.

Spiritual growth is not a right or privilege in Christ. Now that we are in Christ, we are to take advantage of our rights and privileges in Christ.

Observe,

Ephesians 2:8 For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Vs 9 Not of works, lest any man should boast. Vs 10 For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them.

As seen earlier, salvation does not require works however it produces its own works. That is, change of conduct as earlier seen, does not lead to salvation. However, the believer is saved unto good works. We are expected to have good conduct as believers.

Our conduct matters.

Philippians 2:12 Wherefore, my beloved, as ye have always obeyed, not as in my presence only, but now much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling.

The phrase "work out your salvation" already implies that we are saved. Hence, working out salvation implies demonstrating the fruit of salvation that we have. This is spiritual growth.

Just like every concept of growth, it is the pursuit of development to enjoy the benefits of salvation, to walk in the light of what Christ has done and we have received.

Observe,

1st Peter 2:9 But ye are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, an holy nation, a peculiar people; that ye should shew forth the praises of him who hath called you out of darkness into his marvellous light:

The word "praises" implies perfections or virtues.

The showing forth of these virtues; we show forth who we are among men. Hence, it refers to our conduct among men. Hence, spiritual growth involves our conduct among men.

Spiritual growth will be growth from our nature, who we are in Christ.

Similarly,

Philippians 2:15 That ye may be blameless and harmless, the sons of God, without rebuke, in the midst of a crooked and perverse nation, among whom ye shine as lights in the world;

The believer, based on who he is, ought to shine as light in this world, referring to our conduct among men.

Confession- I am a responsible believer so I make a choice to grow up spiritually. I am committed to spiritual growth.

## DAY 8

### WHAT SPIRITUAL GROWTH IS NOT

Having seen that spiritual growth is expected now that we are in Christ, let us observe what spiritual growth is not.

Firstly, spiritual growth is not an increase in years lest we begin to see spiritual growth based on the length of time we have been saved.

An understanding of this will be through a proper understanding of the basics earlier seen of who we are and what we now have in Christ as discussed on earlier days.

Spiritual growth is not an attempt to earn God's favour or his acceptance. Recall that the believer has been accepted in Christ Jesus.

Ephesians 1:6 To the praise of the glory of his grace, wherein he hath made us accepted in the beloved

Also, spiritual growth is not a pursuit of justification. The believer has been justified freely by God's grace.

Romans 5:1 Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ: Vs 2 By whom also we have access by faith into this grace wherein we stand, and rejoice in hope of the glory of God.

Romans 5:15 But not as the offence, so also is the free gift. For if through the offence of one many be dead, much more the grace of God, and the gift by grace, which is by one man, Jesus Christ, hath abounded unto many. Vs 16 And not as it was by one that sinned, so is the gift: for the judgment was by one to condemnation, but the free gift is of many offences unto justification. Vs 17 For if by one man's offence death reigned by one; much more they which receive abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness shall reign in life by one, Jesus Christ.) Vs 18 Therefore as by the offence of one judgment came upon all men to condemnation; even so by the righteousness of one the free gift came upon all men unto justification of life.

Justification is freely given in Christ.

Spiritual growth is not an attempt to guarantee salvation. Our salvation is guaranteed in Christ.

Hebrews 7:22 By so much was Jesus made a surety of a better testament. Vs 23 And they truly were many priests, because they were not suffered to continue by reason of death: Vs 24 But this man, because he continueth ever, hath an unchangeable priesthood. Vs 25 Wherefore he is able also to save them to the uttermost that come unto God by him, seeing he ever liveth to make intercession for them.

Jude 1:24 Now unto him that is able to keep you from falling, and to present you faultless before the presence of his glory with exceeding joy,

Knowing that the work of salvation proceeds from grace simply received by faith, it is important that we do not fall into the error of thinking, that it is all the help we get and then see spiritual growth as our effort to ensure we live right.

Therefore, it is important to note that spiritual growth is not a struggle to live right.

Observe,

Philippians 2:12 Wherefore, my beloved, as ye have always obeyed, not as in my presence only, but now much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling.

Paul gave an instruction to work out our salvation.

However,

Philippians 2:13 For it is God which worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure.

His emphasis is on the fact that it is God who works in us to do his will and to please him.

2nd Corinthians 3:5 Not that we are sufficient of ourselves to think any thing as of ourselves; but our sufficiency is of God;

We are not self-sufficient but God-sufficient.

Ezekiel 36:27 And I will put my spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes, and ye shall keep my judgments, and do them.

By the Spirit of God in us, we can walk in his statutes and do his will.

Confession: I have God's Spirit; I can do His will because He works in me.

## DAY 9

### WHAT IS SPIRITUAL GROWTH

'Christ in us' is the secret of Christian living.

Colossians 1:27 To whom God would make known what is the riches of the glory of this mystery among the Gentiles; which is Christ in you, the hope of glory:

In living for Christ, Christ lives through us.

Colossians 2:6 As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in him: Vs 7 Rooted and built up in him, and stablished in the faith, as ye have been taught, abounding therein with thanksgiving.

We received Christ by the word which is faith in the gospel.

James 1:18 Of his own will begat he us with the word of truth, that we should be a kind of firstfruits of his creatures.

1st Peter 1:23 Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever... Vs 25 But the word of the Lord endureth for ever. And this is the word which by the gospel is preached unto you.

The way to walk in Christ is to walk in the Word. Hence, we must feed on Christ by feeding on God's word.

Hence, as we focus on the word, we focus on Christ and Christ lives and functions through us. Hence, spiritual growth is primarily a function of knowledge.

Ephesians 4:11 And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; Vs 12 For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ: Vs 13 Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ: Vs 14 That we henceforth be no more children, tossed to and fro, and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the sleight of men, and cunning craftiness, whereby they lie in wait to deceive; Vs 15 But speaking the truth in love, may grow up into him in all things, which is the head, even Christ:

Paul explained the unity of faith as the knowledge of the son of God. When we all come in unity of faith, we will no longer be children (characterized by being tossed to and fro), rather, we will grow up in Christ.

Hence, the meal for spiritual growth is the knowledge of the son, Christ. When we feed on Christ, we grow up into him.

Philemon 1:6 That the communication of thy faith may become effectual by the acknowledging of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus.

The word "acknowledging" implies to have precise and accurate understanding of all that is ours in Christ. This is the key to spiritual growth.

1st Peter 2:2 As newborn babes, desire the sincere milk of the word, that ye may grow thereby:

2nd Peter 3:18 But grow in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ. To him be glory both now and for ever. Amen.

Growing in grace is to grow in the knowledge of Christ.

Also,

Acts 20:32 And now, brethren, I commend you to God, and to the word of his grace, which is able to build you up, and to give you an inheritance among all them which are sanctified.

Spiritual growth starts and continues when we look into the word of God. Then, our focus is on who we are, what we have and all we can do in Christ.

Confession I focus on the Word and allow the Word of God to work through my life and I grow up spiritually.

DAY 10

WHAT IS SPIRITUAL GROWTH - WALKING IN THE SPIRIT

Spiritual growth is walking in the spirit.

Galatians 5:24 And they that are Christ's have crucified the flesh with the affections and lusts. Vs 25 If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit.

We can walk in the spirit because we are born of the spirit. Therefore, Paul instructs the believer to walk in the spirit.

Observe the context,

Galatians 5:22 But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, Vs 23 Meekness, temperance: against such there is no law.

The word "fruit" can be used to refer to several activities, which also includes a man's actions/ conduct. Thus, the word "fruit" in this context can be better understood as "the result of" or "the product of".

Therefore, Paul was explaining the result of the New Birth; the indwelling of the Spirit in the believer.

Hence Paul's instruction to them.

Galatians 5:16 This I say then, Walk in the Spirit, and ye shall not fulfil the lust of the flesh...  
Vs 25 If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit.

The believer can walk in the Spirit because he has received the Spirit, and he is in the Spirit (he has begun in the Spirit (Galatians 3:1-3))

In verse 16, Paul expressly stated; walk in the Spirit and ye shall not fulfil the lust of the flesh. That is, when a believer walks in his nature (the Spirit), he will not fulfil the lusts (desires) of the flesh (not having the spirit (Romans 8:5)). Therefore, we can walk in the Spirit because we have begun in the Spirit (Galatians 3:2).

Hence in Galatians 5:16, he meant - walk in your nature. This walk refers to a walk from salvation and not a walk to receive salvation.

Therefore, in Galatians 4, He spoke of Christ being formed in them.

Galatians 4:19 My little children, of whom I travail in birth again until Christ be formed in you,

Hence, the walk in the spirit refers to Christ being expressed in our thoughts, words and actions (character). It is the forming of Christ in and through us; expressed in our thoughts, words, desires and conduct. Hence, to walk in the spirit is to walk in who we are in Christ. Walking in the spirit is Christ being formed and moulded in the believer's desires, words, and actions.

Confession - I walk in the spirit. My words, thoughts and actions align to who I am in Christ; I am born of the spirit.

## DAY 11

### DEVOTION

Having seen that as believers, we are children of God which means that God is our Father, it is very important to know that in living the Christian life (growing up spiritually), it is critical to have a vibrant and fervent relationship with the father in Devotion.

Devotion implies the expression and cultivation of our love, longing, thirst and desire for God. Thus, we spend quality time to fellowship with God, to talk to him and hear from him in prayer and feeding/meditating on His word.

David in his Psalms wrote about his desire and thirst for God.

Psalms 42:1 As the hart panteth after the water brooks, so panteth my soul after thee, O God.  
Vs2 My soul thirsteth for God, for the living God: when shall I come and appear before God?

The scriptures are replete with examples of men of God who observed devotion.

Genesis 19:27 And Abraham gat up early in the morning to the place where he stood before the LORD:

Abraham wakes early in the morning to stand before the Lord. Observe that Abraham's devotion was early in the morning.

Also,

1 Samuel 1:19 And they rose up in the morning early, and worshipped before the LORD, and returned, and came to their house to Ramah: and Elkanah knew Hannah his wife, and the LORD remembered her.

Also,

Psalms 57:8... I myself will awake early.

Psalms 63:1 O God, thou art my God; early will I seek thee: my soul thirsteth for thee, my flesh longeth for thee in a dry and thirsty land, where no water is;

He wrote about how he would seek and thirst after God, waking up early in the morning.

Proverbs 8:17 I love them that love me; and those that seek me early shall find me.

Solomon wrote of wisdom in seeking God early.

Isaiah 26:9 With my soul have I desired thee in the night; yea, with my spirit within me will I seek thee early: for when thy judgments are in the earth, the inhabitants of the world will learn righteousness.

Therefore, emphasis was placed on devotion being done early in the morning, that is, before we set out to carry out any activity in the day.

What do we do in devotion?

Devotion involves praise to God in the morning.

1st Chronicles 23:30 And to stand every morning to thank and praise the LORD, and likewise at even;

Devotion involves prayer to God in the morning.

Psalms 5:3 My voice shalt thou hear in the morning, O LORD; in the morning will I direct my prayer unto thee, and will look up.

Psalms 55:17 Evening, and morning, and at noon, will I pray, and cry aloud: and he shall hear my voice.

Devotion involves listening to God's word and hearing from God very early before the drudgery of day.

Isaiah 50:4 The Lord GOD hath given me the tongue of the learned, that I should know how to speak a word in season to him that is weary: he wakeneth morning by morning, he wakeneth mine ear to hear as the learned.

Therefore, our Christian life involves a daily walk which includes a daily life of devotion; a specific time set aside every morning to fellowship with the father; to praise, pray and study/listen to God's word.

Confession - I recognise that my Christian life involves a daily walk with God, a daily life of devotion. I set aside every morning to fellowship with the father; to praise, pray and study/listen to God's word.

DAY 12

PRAYER (1)

An important activity to engage in as believers is Prayer. This is one of the responsibilities we have in Christ.

Recall that, it is one of the activities we engage in during devotion, hence, it is a vital aspect of our Christian life.

It is important to understand firstly that prayer is built on the very foundation of our relationship with the Father.

As a child of God, prayer is fellowship with the Father.

Strong and vibrant relationships are built on regular/consistent communication, hence the need for prayer.

As believers, our relationship with God as Father and worship of Him is cultivated by prayer.

Matthew 6:9 After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name.

Observe,

Matthew 6:5 And when thou prayest, thou shalt not be as the hypocrites are: for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and in the corners of the streets, that they may be seen of men. Verily I say unto you, They have their reward. Vs 6 But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret, and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.

Vs 6.... pray to thy Father in secret...

In other words, Prayer is firstly personal. This implies that the believer should have a time set-apart, away from distractions, public view of people to spend time with God (this is devotion).

Jesus showed us this example,

Mark 1:35 And in the morning, rising up a great while before day, he went out, and departed into a solitary place, and there prayed.

Firstly, Jesus rose up a great while before day. In today's world, it means Jesus rose up between 3am and 4:30am.

Also, Jesus departed into a solitary place. In other words, he left his comfort zone or a public place to a private place where he would be alone with God.

Therefore, as believers, we must cultivate a personal/ private life of prayer.

However, this does not take away the fact that we must also be given to praying with people (corporate prayer). As believers, we should join corporate prayer group meetings in Church.

The scriptures are replete with examples of believers gathered together to pray.

Acts 1:14 These all continued with one accord in prayer and supplication, with the women, and Mary the mother of Jesus, and with his brethren.

Believers gathered in one accord to pray. They spent time praying together.

Acts 2:42 And they continued stedfastly in the apostles doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in prayers.

They continued together in prayers.

Acts 3:1 Now Peter and John went up together into the temple at the hour of prayer,

The church had an hour of prayer. Peter and John were going for a prayer meeting in the church.

Acts 4:23 And being let go, they went to their own company, and reported all that the chief priests and elders had said unto them. Vs 24 And when they heard that, they lifted up their voice to God with one accord, and said, Lord, thou art God, which hast made heaven, and earth, and the sea, and all that in them is... Vs 31 And when they had prayed, the place was shaken where they were assembled together; and they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and they spake the word of God with boldness.

When they were threatened in the preaching of the Gospel, they gathered in church to pray.

Similarly, they gathered to pray for Peter's release.

Acts 12:5 Peter therefore was kept in prison: but prayer was made without ceasing of the church unto God for him. Vs 12 And when he had considered the thing, he came to the house of Mary the mother of John, whose surname was Mark; where many were gathered together praying.

Therefore, as believers, we must consistently and regularly give ourselves to prayer; individually and corporately; together with other believers.

Prayer must not be an elective activity or taken as a hobby, rather, it must be our culture.

Confession-I cultivate a consistent life of prayer. I deliberately give myself to prayer, individually and corporately with other believers.

DAY 13

## PRAYER (2) - LENGTH OF PRAYER

Having seen how important it is for us as believers to be given to prayer.

### HOW LONG DO/SHOULD WE PRAY?

This implies, how long do I communicate or fellowship with God in the place of prayer.

Our understanding of what prayer is will inform an easy answer to this question. Recall that prayer is fellowship with the father.

In a natural relationship, for example, the lesser the communication, the more likely such a relationship would break up with time because in any relationship whatsoever, talking/communication is key.

People hardly get bored whilst talking with spouses/best friends.

Observe Jesus,

Luke 6:12 And it came to pass in those days, that he went out into a mountain to pray, and continued all night in prayer to God. Vs 13 And when it was day, he called unto him his disciples: and of them he chose twelve, whom also he named apostles;

Jesus prayed for long because he had a vibrant fellowship with the Father. Here, he prayed for at least six (6) hours.

Observe,

Matthew 6:7 But when ye pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do: for they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking. Vs8 Be not ye therefore like unto them: for your Father knoweth what things ye have need of, before ye ask him.

Jesus admonished them not to pray as heathens/unbelievers who do not have a relationship with the Father. He described the way they pray; vain repetitions (that is, with much speaking).

However, it is important to note that Jesus is not discouraging long prayer time.

The word "vain repetitions" here refers to empty speaking, speaking without meaning, purpose or reason. Looking at the context (vs 19-34), they prayed with much worry and anxiety. This explains the vain repetition and much speaking.

He lets us see exactly what believers pray for which distinguishes us from the unbeliever.

Vs 9 After this manner therefore pray ye: Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Vs 10 Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.

Therefore, the focus of the believer's prayer is God; His will, His plans above any other.

Hence, for these reasons, the believer cannot/ should not get tired of praying long hours.

However, we could take a cue for the minimum hour to pray from Jesus' words to his disciples.

Matthew 26:40 And he cometh unto the disciples, and findeth them asleep, and saith unto Peter, What, could ye not watch with me one hour? Vs 41 Watch and pray, that ye enter not into temptation: the spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak,

Hence, we can infer that the minimum time expected/required for any Christian to pray is one (1) hour and the same applies for a church prayer group meeting.

Furthermore, scriptures are replete with instructions as touching regularity and consistency in prayer.

Luke 18:1 And he spake a parable unto them to this end, that men ought always to pray, and not to faint;

The word "faint" does not mean to go into unconsciousness but rather it means to "give up/to turn out badly/to lose steam or energy.

Therefore, the effectiveness and quality of prayer is predicated on the quantity or amount of time spent praying.

The Epistles are also replete with instructions to pray always.

Ephesians 6:18 Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints

Romans 12:12 Rejoicing in hope; patient in tribulation; continuing instant in prayer;

1 Thessalonians 5:17 Pray without ceasing

The word "ceasing" can also infer "season" which implies that there must not be seasons to prayer. Rather, prayer must be done always.

Also, Paul wrote about how he prayed for the church ceaselessly.

Ephesians 1:15 Wherefore I also, after I heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus, and love unto all the saints, Vs 16 Cease not to give thanks for you, making mention of you in my prayers;

Philemon 1:4 I thank my God, making mention of thee always in my prayers,

Colossians 1:9 For this cause we also, since the day we heard it, do not cease to pray for you, and to desire that ye might be filled with the knowledge of his will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding;

Therefore, as believers, we ought to be given to prayer. There are no restrictions to the length of prayer. The believer must be given to prayer consistently and regularly.

Confession- I give myself more to prayer and to long hours of prayer on a regular basis.

DAY 14

HOW DO WE PRAY? - PRAYING IN THE SPIRIT

As believers, we ought to know how to pray.

Ephesians 6:18 Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints;

Paul explains that prayer ought to be made always in the spirit.

What does it mean to pray in the spirit?

1st Corinthians 14:2 For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

Paul explains that speaking in tongues is speaking in the spirit. Hence, praying in the spirit is praying in tongues.

It is important to note that every believer can and should talk in tongues.

Mark 16:17 And these signs shall follow them that believe; In my name shall they cast out devils; they shall speak with new tongues;

Tongues is a sign that follows everyone that believes.

Why can the believer speak in tongues?

Recall that speaking in tongues is speaking in/by the spirit.

Also,

Acts 2:4 And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.

Tongues is an utterance of/by/from the spirit.

Also recall that every believer has the spirit of God. Hence, every believer can and should talk in tongues.

Acts 10:44 While Peter yet spake these words, the Holy Ghost fell on all them which heard the word. Vs 45 And they of the circumcision which believed were astonished, as many as came with Peter, because that on the Gentiles also was poured out the gift of the Holy Ghost. Vs 46 For they heard them speak with tongues, and magnify God. Then answered Peter,

Acts 19:5 When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus. Vs 6 And when Paul had laid his hands upon them, the Holy Ghost came on them; and they spake with tongues, and prophesied.

Every believer can speak in tongues.

The word "speaketh" (Mark 16:17, 1st Corinthians 14:2) was translated from the Greek word "laleo", which implies regular speaking.

In other words, for the believer, speaking in tongues is our regular or natural mode of communication with the Father.

Hence, it forms part of the believer's fellowship or devotion to the Father individually and in church meetings/believers' gatherings.

Paul was a man given to so much speaking with tongues.

1 Corinthians 14:14 For if I pray in an unknown tongue, my spirit prayeth, but my understanding is unfruitful... Vs 18 I thank my God, I speak with tongues more than ye all

It means therefore that his prayers contained in his letters to the churches were done primarily in the tongues and subsequently documented in his epistles to them.

Therefore, Paul admonished us as believers to do same in our personal devotion and church gatherings/meetings.

Ephesians 6:18 Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints;

1 Corinthians 14:23 If therefore the whole church be come together into one place, and all speak with tongues, and there come in those that are unlearned, or unbelievers, will they not say that ye are mad?

The whole Church can come together to pray (speak to God) in tongues.

Also,

1<sup>a</sup> Corinthians 14:4 He that speaketh in an unknown tongue edifieth himself; but he that prophesieth edifieth the church.

Tongues is for prayer and also for our spiritual growth. It edifies us. Jude taught this same truth in his Epistle;

Jude 1:20 But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost,

The phrase "building up" was translated from the same word as "edify". It implies to strengthen or establish.

Hence, firstly, every time the believer prays, he should pray in the spirit (in tongues). Secondly, every time the believer prays in tongues, he is strengthened, energized and emboldened in his Christian walk.

Confession- Every time I pray, I choose to pray in the Spirit (Tongues). As I pray in the Spirit, I am emboldened, strengthened in my Christian walk.

## DAY 15

### MEDITATING ON THE WORD (1)

Recall that spiritual growth starts and continues when we look into the word of God. Hence, as believers, we are instructed to feed and meditate on God's word.

The word of God is food; that is, what a believer must feed on regularly (DAILY) as a means of sustenance.

Psalms 119:103 How sweet are thy words unto my taste! yea, sweeter than honey to my mouth!

This implies what is eaten and is pleasurable to taste, which is a depiction of food.

"...sweeter than honey to my mouth.."

It is important to note that honey is often employed to describe how sweet something is ("as sweet as honey"). However, note that he describes the word of God as "sweeter than honey" to describe his delight in God's word.

David wrote this with the background in Moses' writing.

Deuteronomy 8:3 that he might make thee know that man doth not live by bread only, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of the LORD doth man live.

Jesus referenced this;

Matthew 4:2 And when he had fasted forty days and forty nights, he was afterward an hungred. Vs 3 And when the tempter came to him, he said, If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread. Vs 4 But he answered and said, It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God.

Also Job,

Job 23:12 Neither have I gone back from the commandment of his lips; I have esteemed the words of his mouth more than my necessary food.

Job esteemed, regarded and treated the word of God more than his necessary food.

Therefore, the Word of God is very important to the believer.

Philemon 6 That the communication of thy faith may become effectual by the acknowledging of every good thing which is in you in Christ Jesus.

The word "acknowledging" implies to have precise and accurate understanding of every good thing in us in Christ. This will be found in God's word.

2nd Peter 3:18 But grow in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ. To him be glory both now and for ever. Amen.

Growing in grace is growth in the knowledge of Christ.

Therefore,

1st Peter 2:2 As newborn babes, desire the sincere milk of the word, that ye may grow thereby:

The word "desire" implies to crave for and long for something.

Therefore, the believer must desire; crave for the word of God.

Confession- The word of God is food to me, and I choose to feed on it daily for my sustenance. As I do, I keep growing in the knowledge of Christ.

DAY 16

## MEDITATING ON THE WORD (2)

Having seen the importance of God's word to the believer, let us observe instructions given to the believer concerning the word of God.

The Scriptures instruct to meditate on God's word daily.

Psalms 1:1 Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful. Vs 2 But his delight is in the law of the LORD; and in his law doth he meditate day and night.

Similarly,

Joshua 1:8 This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success.

Observe that he says that in meditation, the word will not depart from your mouth. Hence, the word "meditate" implies to ponder and mutter to oneself.

Paul also gave the instruction.

1st Timothy 4:15 Meditate upon these things; give thyself wholly to them; that thy profiting may appear to all.

It implies to think deeply upon, to revolve in the mind or to look at an object in the mind from every angle.

Hence Paul says, "give thyself wholly to them".

Paul was referring to the things that he taught him. Timothy was to meditate on them by giving himself wholly unto them, then his profiting would appear unto all.

Let us observe certain things in the scriptures quoted as touching meditation:

They let us see how frequently the believer ought to meditate.

Psalms 1:2... day and night

Joshua 1:8-...day and night

The phrase "day and night" would imply regularly, consistently that is, daily. Hence, as believers, we must meditate on God's word consistently.

- The end result of meditation

Psalm 1:3 And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water, that bringeth forth his fruit in his season; his leaf also shall not wither; and whatsoever he doeth shall prosper.

Similarly,

Joshua 1:8 ...thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success.

1st Timothy 4:15 ... that thy profiting may appear to all.

The profiting will imply the essence of God's word to the believer; our mind is renewed (Romans 12:2) and this reflects in our conduct.

James in his epistle also admonished the believer to meditate on the word;

James 1:21 Wherefore lay apart all filthiness and superfluity of naughtiness, and receive with meekness the engrafted word, which is able to save your souls. Vs 22 But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves. Vs 23 For if any be a hearer of the word, and not a doer, he is like unto a man beholding his natural face in a glass: Vs 24 For he beholdeth himself, and goeth his way, and straightway forgetteth what manner of man he was. Vs 25 But whoso looketh into the perfect law of liberty, and continueth therein, he being not a forgetful hearer, but a doer of the work, this man shall be blessed in his deed.

Verse 22

The word "deceiving" implies to act beside oneself.

James had initially explained to them that they are born of God's will (verse 18), but a refusal to act on the word is acting besides themselves.

Verse 23-25

James likened the word of God to a mirror. In essence, God's word gives a reflection of who the believer is to him.

However, if he hears it and does not make a practice of the same, it means he does not give attention to the word he has heard. That is, he does not meditate on it consistently.

Hence, such a believer is referred to as a forgetful hearer.

The word "forget" implies laying aside, it is not a memory loss. rather, it is to lay aside what you know for something else, in this context, for the word of God.

He describes the forgetful hearer as the man that stops looking hence, he deceives himself. That is, he is not acting in the light of who he is.

A doer of the Word is the believer that continues to look in the law of perfect liberty and he is blessed in his deeds.

Therefore, James as other explained texts taught that as believers, we are to give ourselves to meditation on the word, to the end that our mind is renewed. This eventually affects our words and actions towards others.

Confession-God's word gives a reflection of who I am in Christ to me. I keep hearing it and make practice of the same.

DAY 17

YOU HAVE BEEN CALLED INTO GOD'S FAMILY

Ephesians 2:18 For through him we both have access by one Spirit unto the Father. Vs 19 Now therefore ye are no more strangers and foreigners, but fellow citizens with the Saints, and of the household of God;

The word 'household' is the word family hence a believer is a member of God's family. This household is also referred to as the Church.

The Church is the body of Christ, and it involves members who are believers. A man belongs to the body of Christ when he believes in the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus.

1st Corinthians 12:12 For as the body is one, and hath many members, and all the members of that one body, being many, are one body: so also is Christ. Vs 13 For by one Spirit are we all baptized into one body, whether we be Jews or Gentiles, whether we be bond or free; and have been all made to drink into one Spirit. Vs 14 For the body is not one member, but many.

Therefore, we are identified with the church by the new birth.

Hebrews 2:10 For it became him, for whom are all things, and by whom are all things, in bringing many sons unto glory, to make the captain of their salvation perfect through sufferings. Vs 11 For both he that sanctifieth and they who are sanctified are all of one: for which cause he is not ashamed to call them brethren, Vs 12 Saying, I will declare thy name unto my brethren, in the midst of the church will I sing praise unto thee.

Christ by his resurrection has made us sons and called us brethren, His church.

The word, "church" means to be called out (from death, sin, from this world). Hence, because we belong to the body of Christ, we have been called out into a people; a family; a gathering.

The gathering of saints is God's plan for the earth.

The writer of Hebrews instructs believers as touching gatherings.

Hebrews 10:23 Let us hold fast the profession of our faith without wavering; (for he is faithful that promised;) Vs 24 And let us consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works: Vs 25 Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as the manner of some is; but exhorting

The word "provoke" here implies to stimulate. The first thing after salvation is fellowship, we are saved unto fellowship; into a family.

The word "not forsaking" implies not to disregard or desert, and it is a function of an attitude. This is as practical as exempting yourself from Christian meetings.

He explained that the role of that believer (the saint) in the assembly is to stimulate (inspire) others unto love and good works.

Paul taught the same truth as "edifying"

1st Corinthians 14:26 How is it then, brethren? when ye come together, every one of you hath a psalm, hath a doctrine, hath a tongue, hath a revelation, hath an interpretation. Let all things be done unto edifying

The word 'assembling (Hebrews 10:24) refers to a physical gathering, used literally for gathering things.

The instruction is not to forsake the gathering of believers, coming together as the church. This can be referred to as the LOCAL CHURCH, an assembly.

We are not saved to isolation, but to a family.

## THE LOCAL CHURCH IN THE BOOK OF ACTS

In the book of Acts, we would observe an emphasis on the local church, men gathered together consistently. The emphasis of "the book of Acts" concerning the church is the gathering of believers.

Acts 1:4 And, being assembled together with them, commanded them that they should not depart from Jerusalem, but wait for the promise of the Father, which, saith he, ye have heard of me.

When Jesus was going to leave the earth physically, he addressed his disciples in an assembly. Also the great commission was directed to a gathering (Matthew 28:18-20; Mark 16:15-20; Luke 24:47, 49, John 20:21-23).

Also,

Acts 1:14 These all continued with one accord in prayer and supplication, with the women, and Mary the mother of Jesus, and with his brethren.

We see further examples in the book of Acts; when men believed the gospel, the apostles ensured that they fellowshiped with them.

Acts 2:41 Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls. Vs 42 And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in prayers.

They continued steadfastly in the apostles' doctrine, prayers, breaking of bread and fellowship. When a man is saved, it is unto fellowship.

It is important to know that the gathering is in one place.

Acts 2:1...they were all with one accord in one place.

It was recorded that all were with one accord in one place, a gathering. Therefore, it requires a coming together, and not through the media.

Acts 4:22 For the man was above forty years old, on whom this miracle of healing was shewed. Vs 23 And being let go, they went to their own company, and reported all that the chief priests and elders had said unto them.

After Peter and John were threatened not to preach, they went back to their own company. The word "company" here means a group, gathering, or assembly.

Acts 4:29 And now, Lord, behold their threatenings: and grant unto thy servants, that with all boldness they may speak thy word, Vs 30 By stretching forth thine hand to heal; and that signs and wonders may be done by the name of thy holy child Jesus. Vs 31 And when they had prayed, the place was shaken where they were assembled together; and they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and they spake the word of God with boldness. Vs 32 And the multitude of them that believed were of one heart and of one soul: neither said any of them that ought of the things which he possessed was his own, but they had all things common.

In Verse 31, the place was shaken where they were assembled together. Hence, the company was in a place.

Hence, amid persecution, the apostles still assembled together to pray. Those that believed all had a common goal.

Acts 5:12 And by the hands of the apostles were many signs and wonders wrought among the people; (and they were all with one accord in Solomon's porch. Vs 13 And of the rest durst no man join himself to them: but the people magnified them. Vs 14 And believers were the more added to the Lord, multitudes both of men and women.)

They were with one accord in Solomon's porch; a place.

Observe that though more people were added to their number, they kept coming together. In essence, an increase in membership did not hinder the gathering of believers together.

Acts 8:1 And Saul was consenting unto his death. And at that time there was a great persecution against the church which was at Jerusalem; and they were all scattered abroad throughout the regions of Judaea and Samaria, except the apostles.

Observe that the church was at Jerusalem. Hence, the church had a location.

Similarly,

Acts 11:26 And when he had found him, he brought him unto Antioch. And it came to pass, that a whole year they assembled themselves with the church, and taught much people. And the disciples were called Christians first in Antioch.

They assembled themselves with the church', that is, they identified and gathered with the church at Antioch

Acts 12:5 Peter therefore was kept in prison: but prayer was made without ceasing of the church unto God for him.

The church gathered to pray for Peter.

Acts 13:1 Now there were in the church that was at Antioch certain prophets and teachers; as Barnabas, and Simeon that was called Niger, and Lucius of Cyrene, and Manaen, which had been brought up with Herod the tetrarch, and Saul.

This was also in the gathering of believers.

Acts 14:21 And when they had preached the gospel to that city, and had taught many, they returned again to Lystra, and to Iconium, and Antioch, Vs 22 Confirming the souls of the disciples, and exhorting them to continue in the faith, and that we must through much tribulation enter into the kingdom of God. Vs 23 And when they had ordained them elders in every church, and had prayed with fasting, they commended them to the lord, on whom they believed.

Luke here recorded that Paul and Barnabas ordained elders in every church, that is, in every assembly of believers.

Thus, the book of Acts focuses a whole lot on gatherings. The church progresses with the gatherings. There is a high premium placed on believers gathering. This is where we are taught, trained, nurtured to grow spiritually and equipped for the work of the ministry.

Ephesians 4:12 For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ:

It is evident from the book of Acts and the Epistles that the importance of the gathering of believers together (local Church) cannot be overemphasized. Therefore, the local church or the gathering of believers together, must be highly esteemed by every believer.

Confession: I acknowledge that I am saved unto fellowship, into a family. I choose to esteem the gathering of believers. This is where I am taught, trained, nurtured to grow spiritually and also equipped for the work of the ministry.

DAY 18

## LOCAL CHURCH: IMPORTANCE OF CHURCH MEETINGS

Having seen that we have been called to a family which is a gathering in a local church place; local church, we therefore must belong to a

Therefore, as a member of a local church, it is our duty to be present at ALL meetings held or organized there. This implies that believers should not cherry pick meetings to attend.

It should be realized that every meeting in the local church is to the end that the members are edified and trained for the work of the ministry. Paul said this much in his letters to the Corinthians and Ephesians respectively.

1st Corinthians 11:17 Now in this that I declare unto you I praise you not, that ye come together not for the better, but for the worse.

The gathering of the believers is to the end that we get better.

Ephesians 4:11 And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; Vsi2 For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ: Vs13 Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ: Vsl4 That we henceforth be no more children, tossed to and fro, and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the sleight of men, and cunning craftiness, whereby they lie in wait to deceive; Vs15 But speaking the truth in love, may grow up into him in all things, which is the head, even Christ. Vs16 From whom the whole body fitly joined together and compacted by that which every joint supplieth, according to the effectual working in the measure of every part, maketh increase of the body unto the edifying of itself in love.

The believer's spiritual growth is tied to Christian meetings.

Also, observe Peter's submission when someone was to be chosen to replace Judas.

Acts 1:21 Wherefore of these men which have companied with us all the time that the Lord Jesus went in and out among us, Vs 22 Beginning from the baptism of John, unto that same day that he was taken up from us, must one be ordained to be a witness with us of his resurrection. Vs 23 And they appointed two, Joseph called Barsabas, who was surnamed Justus, and Matthias.

The persons in view had to:

- Have companied with them all the time,
- Beginning from the baptism of John (Luke 3:21-22),
- Up until the resurrection of Jesus, and his Ascension

Hence, it was important for the person to have been with them all the time, that is, being at all the meetings throughout the course of Jesus earthly ministry. Therefore, as a member of a local church, one should be present at every meeting in that local assembly. For instance, in the book of Acts they had:

Teaching meetings: Acts 2:42, 11:25-26, Acts 19:9-10

Prayer meetings: Acts 1:14, Acts 2:42, Acts 4:23, Acts 12:5

The also had believers' meetings (Holy Ghost Meetings) Acts 2:1-4, 1st Corinthians 14:23-26

They also had house to house meetings, which today can serve as the "cell meetings"; Acts 5:42, Acts 20:20 Believers were also trained to preach the gospel to others; Acts 8:4-5, Acts 11:19-21

Notice that no one was exempt from any of the meetings. Thus, all these meetings must be seen as important, and every believer must ensure that he (she) attends dutifully every meeting held in the local assembly.

This leads us to note another attitude that believers should have towards and in Church meetings.

### IN ONE ACCORD'

From the Book of Acts, one key attitude that they (believers) embodied was being 'in one accord.'

Acts 1:14 These all continued with one accord in prayer and supplication, with the women, and Mary the mother of Jesus, and with his brethren.

Before the day of Pentecost, all the disciples continued in prayer together.

Acts 2:1 And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place.

Acts 2:46 And they, continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, did eat their meat with gladness and singleness of heart,

The phrase 'one accord, implies to be and act in agreement with what others are doing in a church meeting, as determined by the leadership of the local assembly. In other words, believers ought to be found doing the same things that every other participant is doing.

As a believer, what are the simple ways that we can make a practice of this in the local church?

. PRAYING when all other members are PRAYING. SINGING when all other members are SINGING.

- LIFTING HANDS when all other members are LIFTING HANDS.

- LISTENING TO GOD'S WORD when all other members are LISTENING TO GOD'S WORD.

- READING when all other members are READING.

- TAKING DOWN NOTES when the word of God is being taught

To do otherwise at any time is to not be in one accord with other members in the local church.

Confession- I see church meetings as important. I take heed to attend dutifully and be in one accord in every meeting held in my local assembly.

DAY 19

## HOW I OUGHT TO BEHAVE IN THE LOCAL CHURCH

An important fact that every believer ought to understand is that the local Church is a place of order. Paul echoed this fact in his first letter to the church in Corinth.

1st Corinthians 11:34 And if any man hunger, let him eat at home; that ye come not together unto condemnation. And the rest will I set in order when I come.

Also,

1 Corinthians 14:40 Let all things be done decently and order

The immediate context here was concerning the demonstration of the gifts of the Spirit. Hence, when we come together, we have the same instructions as touching orderliness.

This explains why he wrote in his first letter to Timothy.

1 Timothy 3:14 These things write I unto thee, hoping to, come unto thee shortly: Vs 15 But if I tarry long, that thou, mayest know how thou oughtest to behave thyself in the house of God, which is the church of the living God, the pillar and ground of the truth.

Hence, there is a way we must conduct ourselves in the local Church (the gathering of believers). The phrase "that thou mayest know how thou oughtest to behave thyself in the house of God" clearly implies that NO ONE has the right to behave anyhow.

From Paul's words in the above texts, it is evident that every activity in the local Church must be done decently and orderly. Thus, the reason for authority in the local assembly, is orderliness.

This explains why Paul in his introductory words said to Timothy;

1st Timothy 1:3 As I besought thee to abide still at Ephesus, when I went into Macedonia, that thou mightest charge some that they teach no other doctrine, Vs 4 Neither give heed to fables and endless genealogies, Which minister questions, rather than godly edifying which is in faith: so do.

Timothy was the one to ensure that no one in Ephesus taught any other doctrine.

1st Timothy 3:1 This is a true saying, If a man desire the office of a bishop, he desireth a good work. Vs 2 A bishop then must be blameless, the husband of one wife, vigilant, sober, of good behaviour, given to hospitality, apt to teach;

He was to appoint bishops; those who have oversight functions (via the teaching of God's word) in the lives of people, at Ephesus).

2nd Timothy 2:1 Thou therefore, my son, be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus. Vs 2 And the things that thou hast heard of me among many witnesses, the same commit thou to faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also.

He was the one who had the responsibility of committing Paul's teachings to others at Ephesus.

Clearly, Timothy was the Pastor of the Church at Ephesus,

Paul gave similar instructions to Titus.

Titus 1:5 For this cause left I thee in Crete, that thou shouldest set in order the things that are wanting, and ordain elders in every city, as I had appointed thee:

Similar to Timothy, Titus was the Pastor of the Church at Crete.

In other words, Timothy and Titus were sent by Paul to bring orderliness to the churches at Ephesus and Crete respectively. This explains why he gave them several instructions as touching believers and activities in the local assembly.

One important attitude that the believer must have to the gathering of the saints is;

- Punctuality

The believer ought to be punctual to all Christian meetings. The truth is that no one is late to meetings that they hold in high esteem and seriousness.

Christian meetings have definite times.

For instance, in the book of Acts, Luke recorded that Peter and John went to the temple at the "hour of prayer" (Act 3:1)

This implies that there was a time dedicated for prayer meetings by the apostles in the church at Jerusalem.

Consider the account in Acts 2;

Acts 2:1 And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place.

Upon Jesus' instruction to the apostles to wait in Jerusalem to be endued with power from on High (Luke 24:49, Acts 1:4-5, Acts 1:8), on the day of Pentecost, they all gathered in one accord as instructed.

This implied no one got in late or was absent. In essence, the service of God ought to be attended to with the attitude of punctuality. This is how we ought to treat all Christian meeting.

It is important to know that every part of a church service is vital to the spiritual growth and edification of each believer present. Hence, punctuality should not be seen as a suggestion but an instruction.

In essence, punctuality to our gatherings proves our honour, and love for fellow believers and the local church.

Also, church meetings must be attended with a sense of duty and seriousness. Hence, it is essential that believers attend meetings with a Bible and writing materials. This is based on our understanding that the local church serves as a place of teaching and training by God's word.

Confession- There is a way I must conduct myself in my local Church, as I am not to behave improperly. I attend all church meetings punctually. This proves my honour, and love for fellow believers and my local church.

## DAY 20

### HOW I OUGHT TO BEHAVE IN THE LOCAL CHURCH (HONOUR FOR FELLOW BELIEVERS)

Another vital attitude to embody in the local church is to honour every member of the local church.

Honour means to treat with respect and regard as sacred. We have apostolic instructions to treat believers with honour.

Romans 12:9 Let love be without dissimulation. Abhor that which is evil; cleave to that which is good. Vs 10 Be kindly affectioned one to another with brotherly love; in honour preferring one another;

In honouring believers, it is vital to recognise from the written word, the reality of who the believer is in Christ. Honour starts by seeing believers the same way God sees them.

- Every believer is indwelt by the Holy Spirit

1st Corinthians 2:12 Now we have received, not the spirit of the world, but the spirit which is of God; that we might know the things that are freely given to us of God.

- Every believer is sanctified

Hebrews 10:10 By the which will we are sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all. Vs 14 For by one offering he hath perfected for ever them that are sanctified.

- Every believer is the temple of God

2nd Corinthians 6:14 Be ye not unequally yoked together with unbelievers: for what fellowship hath righteousness with unrighteousness? and what communion hath light with darkness? Vs 15 And what concord hath Christ with Belial? or what part hath he that believeth with an infidel? Vs 16 And what agreement hath the temple of God with idols? for ye are the temple of the living God; as God hath said, I will dwell in them, and walk in them; and I will by their God, and they shall be my people.

Therefore, the believer is indeed sacred and ought to be treated as such. We must not treat the believers any less than they are. We must recognize, relate with and treat believers as members of the same body - the family of God; our family.

Ephesians 3:14 For this cause I bow my knees unto the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, Vs 15 Of whom the whole family in heaven and earth is named,

Galatians 6:10 As we have therefore opportunity, let us do good unto all men, especially unto them who are of the household of faith

Therefore, we have a duty to treat our brethren in Christ with utmost regard and respect.

In walking in honour towards members in the local church, we will walk in love towards them as instructed by the scriptures.

Romans 12:9 Let love be without dissimulation. Abhor that which is evil; cleave to that which is good. Vs 10 Be kindly affectioned one to another with brotherly love; in honour preferring one another;

Ephesians 4:31 Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice: Vs 32 And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

Ephesians 5:1 Be ye therefore followers of God, as dear children; Vs 2 And walk in love, as Christ also hath loved us, and hath given himself for us an offering and a sacrifice to God for a sweetsmelling savour.

In other words, to honour fellow believers, is to walk in love towards them. As we walk in love towards believers, we give no room to strife rather we forgive whenever we are offended.

This explains why Paul taught in his first letter to the Corinthians

1st Corinthians 6:1 Dare any of you, having a matter against another, go to law before the unjust, and not before the saints? Vs 2 Do ye not know that the saints shall judge the world? and if the world shall be judged by you, are ye unworthy to judge the smallest matters? Vs 3 Know ye not that we shall judge angels? how much more things that pertain to this life? Vs 4 If then ye have judgments of things pertaining to this life, set them to judge who are least esteemed in the church. Vs 5 I speak to your shame. Is it so, that there is not a wise man among you? no, not one that shall be able to judge between his brethren? Vs 6 But brother goeth to law with brother, and that before the unbelievers Vs 7 Now therefore there is utterly a fault among you, because ye go to law one with another. Why do ye not rather take wrong? why do ye not rather suffer yourselves to be defrauded? Vs 8 Nay, ye do wrong, and defraud, and that your brethren.

Indisputably, it is wrong to treat fellow believers like ordinary people even when they are wrong, hence, he expressly stated why not rather suffer wrong?",

He explained this further in Chapter 13

1st Corinthians 13:4 Charity suffereth long, and is kind; charity envieth not; charity vaunteth not itself, is not puffed up, Vs5 Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil; Vs6 Rejoiceth not in iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth; Vs7\_Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things. Vs8 Charity never faileth: but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail; whether there be tongues, they shall cease; whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away.

In essence, we are to respect and have regard for fellow believers and there is no better place to practice this than in the local church.

We are to esteem other believers better than ourselves.

Philippians 2:3 Let nothing be done through strife or vainglory; but in lowliness of mind let each esteem other better than themselves.

In other words, we ought to treat believers better than we would ourselves.

Therefore, it is evident from the above analysis that in identifying with a local church, these attitudes highlighted ought to be imbibing and practiced.

Confession- I choose to see believers the same way God sees them. I stay consistent, punctual to Christian meetings and take notes for further study in private times. I walk in love, honour and regard other believers in my local Church.

DAY 21

## SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY IN CHURCH (WHO ARE OUR CHURCH LEADERS?)

In every institution, whether secular, or spiritual, authority is often evident. Authority implies to be in control or in charge. Hence, in every institution, there is always a leader; one who is in charge. Someone must have the final say for orderliness, peace and unity of purpose to prevail.

For instance:

### In the Marital Relationship

Ephesians 5:22 Wives, submit yourselves unto your own husbands, as unto the Lord, Vs 23 For the husband is the head of the wife, even as Christ is the head of the church: and he is the saviour of the body. Vs 24 Therefore as the church is subject unto Christ, so let the wives be to their own husbands in every thing. Vs 25 Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it

Clearly, the man is the head of marital relationship. Paul teaches the man to love his wife, and the wife to submit to her husband in the marital institution. He teaches it as a godly act.

### In the Parent - Children Relationship

Ephesians 6:1 Children, obey your parents in the Lord: for this is right.

Colossians 3:20 Children, obey your parents in all things :for

this is well pleasing unto the Lord.. Vs 21 Fathers, provoke not children to anger, lest they be discouraged

In this institution, parents by the virtue of birthing a child, caring for the natural needs of the child, exercise authority over the child. The child's responsibility is to be respectful and submissive to the parent's guidance.

### In the Master - Servant Relationship

This institution is birthed by the virtue of working or serving under someone either to earn an income or for the acquisition of skills. For instance, an apprentice serves under a master to acquire skills for a period of time, so he also can be a master at such a skill.

Colossians 3:22 Servants, obey in all things your masters according to the flesh; not with eyeservice, menpleasers; but in singleness of heart, fearing God:

Servants are instructed to serve with singleness of heart and also be in subjection to their masters. Likewise, in the local assembly, we are taught and instructed by the apostles to submit to spiritual authority of the leadership in that assembly.

Jesus is the head of the church.

1st Corinthians 11:3 But I would have you know, that the head of every man is Christ, and the head of the woman is the man; and the head of Christ is God.

Ephesians 1:22 And hath put all things under his feet, and gave him to be the head over all things to the church, Vs 23 Which is his body, the fulness of him that filleth all in all

The word 'head' here, was translated from the Greek word "kephale", which implies authority, it also implies source.

Thus, this clearly implies that all authority flows from him, he has set authority in the local church as well. That is, Christ has put men in leadership in church, hence, in the local church, there is spiritual authority.

Recall that the local church is a place of order.

1st Corinthians 11:34 And if any man hunger, let him eat at home; that ye come not together unto condemnation. And the rest will I set in order when I come.

1st Corinthians 14:40 Let all things be done decently and in order.

Hence, the reason for spiritual authority in the local assembly is orderliness.

The writer of Hebrews helps us to see the importance of spiritual authority.

Hebrews 13:17 Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves: for they watch for your souls, as they that must give account, that they may do it with joy, and not with grief: for that is unprofitable for you.

He describes the role of one with spiritual authority; they watch for our souls.

Clearly, the head of Church placed believers in charge of the spiritual growth of other believers.

Observe Jesus' word to Peter:

John 21:15 So when they had dined, Jesus saith to Simon Peter, Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me more than these? He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee. He saith unto him, Feed my lambs. Vs 16 He saith to him again the second time, Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me? He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee, He

saith unto him, Feed my sheep. Vs 17 He saith unto him the third time, Simon, of Jonas, lovest thou me? Peter was grieved because he said unto him the third time, Lovest thou me? And he said unto him, Lord, thou knowest all things; thou saith unto him, Feed my sheep.

The word 'feed' in verse 16 implies to shepherd. It depicts responsibility and consequently, authority.

This was the same word that Peter taught with in his first epistle.

1st Peter 5:1 The elders which are among you I exhort, who am also an elder, and a witness of the sufferings of Christ, and also a partaker of the glory that shall be revealed: Vs 2 Feed the flock of God which is among you, taking the oversight thereof, not by constraint, but willingly, not for filthy lucre, but of a ready mind; Vs3 Neither as being lords over God's heritage, but being ensamples to the flock. Vst And when the chief Shepherd shall appear, ye shall receive a crown of glory that fadeth not away.

Also Paul in the book of Acts;

Acts 20:28 Take heed therefore unto yourselves, and to all the flock, over the which the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers, to feed the church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood.

Therefore, the local church is an assembly of believers with men placed over us. These men are put in charge of believers to teach, which also involves instructions, corrections and rebuke in view of bringing believers to spiritual maturity.

Thus, spiritual growth is ministered to us by Men.

Confession: The local church is an assembly of believers with men placed over my life. I receive their teaching, instructions, corrections and rebuke which are in view of bringing me to spiritual maturity.

## DAY 22

### SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY IN CHURCH; (HOW TO RECOGNIZE OUR CHURCH LEADERS)

A question that readily comes to mind while examining spiritual authority is "How do I identify men in authority in the Local Church?"

1st Thessalonians 5:12 And we beseech you, brethren, to know them which labour among you, and are over you in the Lord, and admonish you; Vs 13 And to esteem them very highly in love for their work's sake. And be at peace among yourselves. Vs 14 Now we exhort you, brethren, warn them that are unruly, comfort the feebleminded, support the weak, be patient toward all men.

Paul instructed that they are to know those in spiritual authority. Much more, he lets us know how they can be recognised. They are men which labour among us and are over us.

Similarly,

1 Timothy 5:17 Let the elders that rule well be counted worthy of double honour, especially they who labour in word and doctrine.

They labour in word and doctrine.

The writer of Hebrews also,

Hebrews 13:7 Remember them which have the rule over you, who have spoken unto you the word of God: whose faith follow, considering the end of their conversation

Those who speak the word of God to us and have rule over us.

From the above texts, it is evident that those who feed and nurture us with God's word are those being spoken of.

This shows that one who does not have a local church or is not consistent with the gathering of believers would have a hard time recognizing who these people are, and also find it difficult to grow spiritually.

The pattern of the scriptures therefore confirms that a believer ought to have a local church, where he submit to the authority of the leadership (of that local assembly) who have the responsibility from the Lord Jesus, to feed us with the word, to the end that we grow spiritually.

Confession: It is not difficult for me to grow spiritually; as I submit to the authority of the leadership (of my local assembly) who has the responsibility from the Lord Jesus, to feed me with the word, to the end that I grow spiritually.

DAY 23

## SPIRITUAL AUTHORITY IN CHURCH; (HOW TO RESPOND TO OUR CHURCH LEADERS)

Having recognised who has spiritual authority over us, it is important to know how to respond to these men placed over us in the Lord (Spiritual Authority)?

- Honour

It is important to know that honour plays an important role in submission.

1st Timothy 5:17 Let the elders that rule well be counted worthy of double honour, especially they who labour the word and doctrine.

The word "honour" as earlier seen implies to treat as sacred, with regard. It implies to place value on or show reverence. That is, to treat as special or uncommon.

1<sup>a</sup> Thessalonians 5:13 And to esteem them very highly in love for their work's sake. And be at peace among yourselves.

It is impossible to be in submission to what is not valued because submission starts from the heart. When submission is not from the heart, it is hypocritical and eye service.

Therefore, honour precedes submission. Observe that Paul was specific as touching the honor of men who oversee our lives; it must be doubled. That is, honour to these men should supersede honour for other men. It must be noted that a believer's attitude and manner to leadership shows attitude and manner to God's word.

### Accountability

Accountability is a very crucial conduct in submission.

Hebrews 13:17 Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves: for they watch for your souls, they that must give account, that they do it with joy, and not with grief: for that is unprofitable for you.

It involves taking the consent of one's Pastor (shepherd, leader) when making crucial life decisions. It depicts transparency. Anyone who is submissive to his local church would be accountable.

Accountability does not only show honour and respect, it also makes the work of our leaders easier since they are also to give account of our lives to God.

### Obedience

We are to specifically obey and submit to our spiritual leaders and not be unruly.

Obedience would mean, to do what you are told, when and how you were told. In essence, 99.9% obedience is disobedience.

The scriptures warn concerning being unruly;

1 Thessalonians 5:14 Now we exhort you, brethren, warn them that are unruly, comfort to the feebleminded, support the weak, be patient toward all men.

The word 'unruly depicts the opposite of submission.

Paul was so confident of Timothy's adherence to instructions.

Philippians 2:19 But I trust in the Lord Jesus to send Timotheus shortly unto you, that I also may be of good comfort when I know your state. Vs 20 For I have no man likeminded, who will naturally care for your state, Vs 21 For all seek their own, not the things which are Jesus Christ's. Vs 22 But ye know the proof of him, that, as a Son with the father, he hath served with me in the gospel.

Timothy was a minister who served Paul diligently in the gospel and was in submission to him. Hence, Paul also gave several instructions to him because he was certain of his obedience.

Therefore, it is imperative to understand that submission to spiritual authority is of utmost importance in the local church. It helps us to receive the training of the spirit from those who oversee us.

Submission provides an avenue to be corrected and instructed, so there can be orderliness both in the gathering of believers and also in our lives.

No one gets to choose who to submit to. Authority flows from Christ the head of the church and he alone decides who to bestow leadership to in the local church.

The believer must therefore submit to a local church and be accountable there.

Confession: I am not unruly to my church leaders. I know how to respond to them. I walk in honour, I am accountable to them and I submit to their leadership.

## DAY 24

### I AM NOW A DISCIPLE

Matthew 28:18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Vs 19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Vs 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen

Jesus in giving "the Great Commission" to his disciples, says "go and teach all nations.

Hence, when a man is saved after believing the gospel as recorded by Mark (Mark 16:15-16), this aspect, "go and teach" is the next step (as recorded by Matthew).

The word "teach" was translated from the Greek word "mathetes". The word 'math' is an ancient word used for mental effort. It implies to think through something. It deals with a thought pattern. Hence,

the word "mathetes" implies a disciple.

A person who is called a disciple is someone who follows in his mindset. It is a term employed by the Jewish Rabbis. When they have a disciple, they give them the Torah (the Old Testament books) to read, memorise in order for effective communication.

A disciple is like an apprentice learning a skill under a master. Hence, the result is for the disciple to be like the master, Hence, the disciple is a student, one who is learning.

Believers were referred to as disciples in the Book of Acts.

Acts 6:1 And in those days, when the number of disciples was multiplied, there arose a murmuring of Grecians against the Hebrews, because their widows were neglected in the daily ministration. Vs 2 Then the twelve called the multitude of the disciples unto them, and said, It is not reason that we should leave the word of God, and serve the word of God increased; and tables... Vs 7 And the number of the disciples multiplied in Jerusalem greatly; and a great company of the priests were obedient to the faith.

Acts 9:1 And Saul, yet breathing out threatenings and slaughter against the disciples of the Lord, went unto the high priest,... Vs 19 And when he had received meat. he was strengthened. Then was Saul certain days with the disciples which were at Damascus... Vs 25 Then the disciples took him by night, and let him down by the wall in a basket. Vs 26 And when Saul was come to Jerusalem, he assayed to join himself to the disciples: but they were all afraid of him, and believed not that he was a disciple...Vs 38 And forasmuch as Lydda was nigh to Joppa, and the disciples had heard that Peter was there, they sent unto him two men, desiring him that he would not delay to come to them.

Acts 11:26 And when he had found him, he brought him unto Antioch. And it came to pass, that a whole year they assembled themselves with the church, and taught much people. And the disciples were called Christians first in Antioch.. Vs 29 Then the disciples, every man according to his ability, determined to send relief unto the brethren which dwelt in Judaea:

Acts 13:52 And the disciples were filled with joy, and the Holy Ghost.

Acts 14:20 Howbeit, as the disciples stood round about him, he rose up, and came into the city: and the next day he departed with Barnabas to to Derbe... Vs 22 Confirming the souls of the disciples, and exhorting them to continue in the faith, and that we must through much tribulation enter into the kingdom of God... Vs 28 And there they abode long time

with the disciples.

Acts 15:10 Now therefore why tempt ye God, to put a yoke upon the neck of the disciples, which neither our fathers nor we were able to bear?

Acts 18:23 And after he had spent some time there, he departed, and went over all the country of Galatia and Phrygia in order, strengthening all the disciples... Vs 27 And when he was disposed to pass into Achaia, the brethren wrote, exhorting the disciples to receive him: who, when he was come, helped them much which had believed through grace:

Luke 10:38 Now it came to pass, as they went, that he entered into a certain village: and a certain woman named Martha received him into her house. Vs 39 And she had a sister called Mary, which also sat at Jesus' feet, and heard his word.

The phrase "sat at Jesus' feet" is an idiom for someone who is a disciple. It means that she sat among those learning from Jesus.

This shows that she was one of his disciples.

Acts 22:3 I am verily a man which am a Jew, born in Tarsus, a city in Cilicia, yet brought up in this city at the feet of Gamaliel, and taught according to the perfect manner of the law of the fathers, and was zealous toward God, as ye all are this day.

Paul was a student of Gamaliel.

Hence, the phrase "at his feet" is a practice of learning.

Also,

Isaiah 50:4 The Lord GOD hath given me the tongue of the learned, that I should know how to speak a word in season to him that is weary: he wakeneth morning by morning, he wakeneth mine ear to hear as the learned. Vs 5 The Lord GOD hath opened mine ear, and I was not rebellious, neither turned away back.

The word "learned" as referenced by Isaiah implies a disciple. Hence, the disciple is the one who is learning. He is not rebellious rather he is yielding to the training.

In essence, as believers, we ought to be a disciple (a student; a pupil) of Christ, and the local church (the gathering of believers) is where this training and learning in discipleship primarily happens. We are taught to pray, preach, give, submit, walk in love and other christian conduct and character

Confession: I am a believer, I acknowledge I am a disciple. I stay committed in my local church as this is where I receive training and learn discipleship.

DAY 25

## SERVING THE LORD

From the point of salvation, Jesus becomes our Lord. Hence, our responsibility as believers entails serving the Lord. A part of the responsibility of a believer is to serve the Lord.

However, serving the Lord should not be done on individual terms, rather, as taught and instructed in the scriptures.

Paul wrote concerning this in his epistle to the Romans.

Romans 12:11 Not slothful in business; fervent in spirit, serving the Lord;

The word 'not slothful' implies not to be lazy.

The word 'business' refers to work, to be without leisure.

The word fervent' was translated from the Greek word 'zeo' which is used for the boiling point of liquids. It implies something that is done with zeal and enthusiasm.

Hence, believers are to serve the Lord with diligence, zeal, and enthusiasm. This implies that passion, effort, and sense of responsibility cannot be abandoned when the service of the Lord is concerned.

Paul highlighted in the proceeding and preceding verses what it means to serve the Lord.

Romans 12:12 Rejoicing in hope; patient in tribulation; continuing instant in prayer, Vs 13 Distributing to the necessity of saints, given to hospitality. Vs 14 Bless them which persecute you: bless, and curse not. Vs 15 Rejoice with them that do Vs 16 rejoice, and weep with them that weep. Vs 16 Be of the same mind one toward another. Mind not high things, but condescend to men of low estate. Be not wise In your own conceits. Vs 17 Recompense to no man evil for evil. Provide things honest in the sight of all me Vs18 if it be possible, as much as lieth in you live peaceably all men. Vs 19 Dearly beloved, not yourselves, but rather give place unto wrath: for it is written, Vengeance is mine; I will repay, saith the Lord. Vs 20 Therefore if thine; if he thirst, give him drink: for if your enemy hunger, feed him; doing thou shalt heap coals of fire on his head. Vs 21 Be not overcome of evil, but overcome evil with good

In context, notice his explanation of what it means to serve the Lord:

Prayer (Verse 12),

Giving; generosity and hospitality,

Single mindedness, Love among other believers

To honour fellow believers

It will also include:

Evangelism/preaching the gospel

Discipleship/teaching other believers (2nd Corinthians 5:17- 19)

Now, observe Paul's explanation in his epistle to the Philippians.

Philippians 2:6 Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God: Vs 7 But made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant, and was made in the likeness of men: Vs 8 And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the Cross. Vs 9 Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name:

The phrase "being in the form of God" refers to Christ being God. That is, he did not lose his deity as a man.

The phrase 'thought it not robbery' implies that Jesus is God, with all the attributes of God but did not consider laying hold on it. It was therefore a choice for him to look away from who he was.

Observe also that he made himself of no reputation and humbled himself.

The word "humbled" implies to be made low.

He described Jesus as one who took the form of a servant; he humbled himself as a servant. Therefore, service embodies all that Jesus did, he brought himself low In Christ's servant hood, the examples found have become the example of Christian service.

Jesus taught this truth.

John 13:4 He riseth from supper, and laid aside his garments; and took a towel. and girded himself. Vs 5 After that he poureth water into a bason, and began to wash the disciples' feet, and I to wipe them with the towel wherewith he was girded. Vs 6 Then cometh he to Simon Peter: and Peter saith unto him. Lord, dost thou wash my feet? Vs 7 Jesus answered and said unto him, What I do thou knowest not now, but thou shalt know hereafter Vs 8 Peter saith unto him. Thou shalt never wash my feet. Jesus answered him, If I wash thee not, thou hast no part with me. Vs 9 Simon Peter saith not my feet only, but also my hands and my head. Vs 10 Jesus saith to him, He that is washed needeth not save to wash his feet, but is clean every whit; and ye are clean, but not all. Vs 11 For he knew who should betray him: therefore said he, Ye are not all clean. Vs 12 So after he had washed their feet, and had taken his garments, and was set down again, he said unto them, Know ye what I have done in you? Vs 13 Ye call me Master and Lord: and ye say well; for so I am. Vs 14 If I then, your Lord and Master, have washed your feet; ye also ought to wash one another's feet Vs 15 For I have given you an example, that ye should do as I have done to you.

In the above narrative, Jesus took a towel and water to wash the feet of his disciples, then, he wiped them. He explained to them that his action was an example for them to do the same.

John 13:16 Verily, verily, I say unto you, The servant is not greater than his lord; neither he that is sent greater than he that sent him.

Hence, Jesus' example was an example of service.

Peter taught the same truth in his Epistles.

1 Peter 2:21 For even hereunto were ye called: because Christ also suffered for us, leaving us an example, that ye should follow his steps:

John also did in his first epistle.

1st John 3:16 Hereby perceive we the love of God, because he laid down his life for us: and we ought to lay down our lives for the brethren.

He explained that the sacrifice of Jesus (laying down his life) was for our sins (1st John 2:1-2) and also is a pointer to how we ought to sacrifice (lay down our lives) for the brethren.

In essence, it is evident from Jesus' teachings in the synoptic accounts, and his apostles in their letters, that Jesus' servant hood is the example of service that we have as believers.

What does it mean to serve?

1. The first thing about service is to make yourself available, because service is voluntary.

The service to the Lord is different from working to get wages. Service is availability and this must be done faithfully.

2. Secondly, to serve means to be used.

This means I am to be available in my local church to pray for others, to give to meet the need of others, be hospitable to others etc.

A believer should ask salient questions such as;

Who am I in the local church I attend?

What do I do there, besides attending the services?

What department do I serve in my local church?

How do I serve God?

i) I serve with my heart

2nd Chronicles 25:1 Amaziah was twenty and five years old when he began to reign, and he reigned twenty and nine years in Jerusalem. And his mother's name was Jehoaddan of Jerusalem. Vs 2 And he did that which was right in the sight of the LORD, but not with a perfect heart.

My reason/ motive for service is more important to the Lord than what I do to serve him.

ii) I serve with my mind

This deals with for example, one's thoughtfulness before attending church meetings with regard to preparedness; our punctuality, participation in the departments, and submission to spiritual authority in the local assembly.

iii) I serve with my body

1 Corinthians 6:19 What? know ye not that your body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you, which ye have of God, and ye are not your own? Vs 20 For ye are bought with a price: therefore glorify God in your body, and in your spirit, which are God's.

The physical body of the believer is the temple of the Holy Ghost, that is, where God dwells. It therefore belongs to God and should be used to serve the Lord.

iv) I serve the Lord with things that are precious to me This includes one's material substance and making them available for the use of others.

Luke 8:1 And it came to pass afterward, that he went throughout every city and village, preaching and shewing the glad tidings of the kingdom of God: and the twelve were with him, Vs 2 And certain women, which had been healed of evil spirits and infirmities, Mary called Magdalene, out of whom went seven devils, Vs 3 And Joanna the wife of Chuza Herod's steward, and Susanna, and many others, which ministered unto him of their substance.

Mary Magdalene and several other women ministered to Jesus of their substance.

v) I serve the Lord with my time

We ought to make sacrifices to be available to serve others.

Colossians 4:12 Epaphras, who is one of you, a servant of Christ, saluteth you, always labouring fervently for you in prayers, that ye may stand perfect and complete in all the will of God. Vs 13 For I bear him record, that he hath a great zeal for you, and them that are in Laodicea, and them in Hierapolis.

This shows commitment and sacrifice.

Confession: As I grow up spiritually, I give myself much more to serve by being available to be used of God. I serve God with my heart, my mind, my body, my time and things precious to me.

DAY 26

SERVING THE LORD (EVANGELISM)

Serving the Lord includes very importantly, preaching the gospel. Therefore,

WHAT IS EVANGELISM?

Mark 16:15 And he said unto them, Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.

Who is the 'them' that he spoke to?

Mark 16:14 Afterward he appeared unto the eleven as they sat at meat, and upbraided them with their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they believed not them which had seen him after he was risen.

Verse 14; he was talking to the eleven apostles.

He gave them the instruction.

Verse 15; '...go ye into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature...'.

Hence, what is the gospel?

Verse 14; he rebuked them for not believing those who saw him that he had risen.

The gospel is the message that he has risen. He tells them to go into all the world and preach the gospel; that he died, he was buried, and he rose from the dead. AVA

Mark 16:16 He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned.

The emphasis is to go and preach the gospel.

Anyone who does not believe the gospel will be damned.

Similarly,

John 3:16 For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life. Vs 17 For God sent not his Son into the world to condemn the world; but that the world through him might be saved. Vs 18 He that believeth on him is not condemned: but he that believeth not is condemned already, because he hath not believed in the name of the only begotten Son of God.

He that does not believe is condemned. Hence, the preaching of the gospel deals with the eternity of people. Therefore, he places this responsibility in the hands of men.

Observe,

John 20:22 And when he had said this, he breathed on them, and saith unto them, Receive ye the Holy Ghost: Vs 23 Whose soever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them; and whose soever sins ye retain, they are retained.

This is a very great responsibility.

It is, however, important to note that this responsibility was not just given to the disciples. It is the responsibility of every believer to preach the gospel.

2nd Corinthians 5:17 Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new. Vs 18 And all things are of God, who hath reconciled us to himself by Jesus Christ, and hath given to us the ministry of reconciliation; Vs 19 To wit, that God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them; and hath committed unto us the word of reconciliation. Vs 20 Now

then we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech you by us: we pray you in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God.

Since, we are saved, we have been given the ministry of reconciliation. Therefore, as believers, we must give ourselves to fulfil that responsibility.

Evangelism is our responsibility. It is not a hobby or a pastime or a church activity. Men's eternities are dependent on it hence it must be taken very seriously. No believer is excluded from the responsibility of evangelism.

Paul in speaking to Timothy spoke of God's will and desire;

1st Timothy 2:3 For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour; Vs 4 Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth.

God's will is for every man to be saved and as his children and servants, we must pursue this with all our heart.

Confession: I am a disciple of Jesus, I see the preaching of the gospel as my responsibility, an instruction and I obey.

DAY 27

#### DISCIPLESHIP/TEACHING/ RAISING OTHER BELIEVERS

Having seen that the responsibility to preach the gospel has been given to every believer, recall that, when a man receives the gospel, he ought to now be involved in discipleship. Hence, just as we have believed and are disciples of Jesus, we also have the responsibility to make those that we preach to, disciples of the word.

Matthew 28:18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Vs 19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Vs 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Recall that the word "teach" implies to make disciples. It is the process of training people to be students.

Therefore, just as Jesus gave them the mission to preach the gospel for men to be saved, he also gave them the responsibility to make men, disciples. Every believer has a preaching and teaching ministry.

Hence, every time we preach the gospel, making disciples must always be in view.

As seen earlier, Paul in speaking to Timothy spoke of God's will and desire.

1 Timothy 2:3 For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour; Vs 4 Who will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth.

Let us examine Paul as an example;

Acts 19:1 And it came to pass, that, while Apollos was at Corinth, Paul having passed through the upper coasts came to Ephesus: and finding certain disciples, Vs 2 He said unto them, Have ye received the Holy Ghost since ye believed? And they said unto him, We have not so much as heard whether there be any Holy Ghost. Vs 3 And he said unto them, Unto what then were ye baptized? And they said, Unto John's baptism. Vs 4 Then said Paul, John verily baptized with the baptism of repentance, saying unto the people, that they should believe on him which should come after him, that is, on Christ Jesus. Vs :5 When they heard this, they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.

The word "disciples" here in context shows they were not disciples of Jesus. Therefore, Paul preached to them and they got saved (they were baptized in the name of Jesus).

Paul did not stop at them being saved.

Acts 19:8 And he went into the synagogue, and spake boldly for the space of three months, disputing and persuading the things concerning the kingdom of God. Vs 9 But when divers were hardened, and believed not, but spake evil of that way before the multitude, he departed from them, and separated the disciples, disputing daily in the school of one Tyrannus. Vs 10 And this continued by the space of two years; so that all they which dwelt in Asia heard the word of the Lord Jesus, both Jews and Greeks.

He consistently taught those who were saved when he preached the gospel till they were established and became elders.

Acts 20:17 And from Miletus he sent to Ephesus, and called the elders of the church. Vs 18 And when they were come to him, he said unto them, Ye know, from the first day that I came into Asia, after what manner I have been with you at all seasons,

Therefore, we are commissioned to preach the gospel and raise disciples and we should be found doing this.

Confession: I disciple, teach and raise other believers for the work of the ministry, I give myself to be trained in my local church, and I effectively train others. I am effectively involved in discipleship.

DAY 28

## CONDUCT AMONG BELIEVERS-WALKING IN LOVE

Galatians 5:22 But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, Vs 23 Meekness, temperance: against such there is no law.

Observe carefully Paul's emphasis in his explanation, in earlier paragraphs.

Galatians 5: 14 For all the law is fulfilled in one word, even in this; Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. Vs 15 But if ye bite and devour one another, take heed that ye be not consumed one of another. Vs 16 This I sav then, Walk in the Spirit, and ye shall not fulfil the lust the flesh. Vs 17 For the flesh lusteth against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh: and these are contrary the one to the other: so that ye cannot do the things that ye would. Vs 18 But if ye be led of the Spirit, ye are not under the law.

Notice that in Verses 6, 13, 14 Paul spoke about walking in love. Thus, his emphasis was walking in love.

Hence, the fruit of the spirit (result of the Spirit) in believers (indwelling of the Spirit of God in us) is love.

It suffices therefore, that love is the nature of the believer (in Christ). In essence, because we are indwelt by the Spirit of God, we have the ability to walk in love toward others. Love therefore, will be the work of the Spirit in and through us.

Now, in Matthew's account, observe Jesus' explanation.

Matthew 22:35 Then one of them, which was a lawyer, asked him a question, tempting him, and saying, 36 Master, which is the great commandment in the law? 37 Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. 38 This is the first and great commandment. 39 And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself., On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.

Jesus here, evidently was teaching from the Scriptures; (Deuteronomy 6:4-6 and Leviticus 19:18).

Love thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. Love your neighbor as thyself.

In the Epistles, Paul explained the same truth repeatedly in his letter;

Ephesians 1:15 Wherefore I also, after I heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus, and love unto all the saints,

Colossians 1:4 Since we heard of your faith in Christ Jesus, and of the love which ye have to all the saints,

1st Thessalonians 1:3 Remembering without ceasing your work of faith, and labour of love, and patience of hope in our Lord Jesus Christ, in the sight of God and our Father,

2nd Thessalonians 1:3 We are bound to thank God always for you, brethren, as it is meet, because that your faith groweth exceedingly, and the charity of every one of you all toward each other aboundeth;

Philemon 1:5 Hearing of thy love and faith, which thou hast toward the Lord Jesus, and toward all saints;

In other words, the fruit of our love for God (faith in God), is our love towards all saints (fellow believers). This explains why the Epistles are replete with instructions for us (believers) to walk in love towards others,

1st Peter 1:22 Seeing ye have purified your souls in obeying the truth through the Spirit unto unfeigned love of the brethren, see that ye love one another with a pure heart fervently:

James 2:8 If ye fulfil the royal law according to the scripture, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself, ye do well:

1st John 4:11-12 Beloved, if God so loved us, we ought also to love one another. Vs 12 No man hath seen God at any time. If we love one another, God dwelleth in us, and his love is perfected in us.

Hebrews 13:1 Let brotherly love continue

Thus, we have the responsibility (as believers) to walk in love towards one another.

Confession: I am born of the Spirit, Love is my nature, it is the result of the Spirit of God dwelling in me. I walk in love towards other believers in my local church. I consciously act on God's word, and I walk in love.

DAY 29

## CONDUCT AMONG BELIEVERS- DEALING WITH OFFENCES

Ephesians 4:32 And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

Paul taught and instructed us (believers) to follow God's example and forgive one another.

It is pertinent to understand that forgiveness is the foundation and strength of every relationship. Two people who know how to forgive will keep their relationship for long. We will build very strong relationships if we learn to forgive one another. Relationships are built on the abilities of the parties to forgive.

Evidently, the reason our salvation is eternal is because, God forgives forever.

Hebrews 8:12 For I will be merciful to their unrighteousness, and their sins and their iniquities will I remember no more.

Hebrews 10:17 And their sins and iniquities will I remember no more.

This relationship is based on His eternal mercies. It therefore implies we cannot learn forgiveness outside of what God has done for us.

Observe Paul's admonition in Ephesians 4; He instructs to forgive as God in Christ forgave us.

Ephesians 4:32 And be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.

In essence, this is the basis of our walk, in forgiveness.

Ephesians 5:1 be ye therefore followers of God as dear children

The word "follower" means to imitate. Thus, we imitate God because we have His Spirit in us. Therefore, walking in love becomes our nature in Christ because the Spirit of God enables us to forgive others as God forgave us.

Love without forgiveness and sacrifice is unfruitful. True love means to give, it is substantial and must be sacrificial. It means something you grant unconditionally; freely. Biblical forgiveness is to do to others what God has done to you. Forgiveness without restoration or reconciliation is hypocrisy. Hence, where there is forgiveness, there is restoration. That means, the person is able to freely relate with you. Forgiveness is demonstrated with restoration of dignity and persons.

Now, the question that readily comes to the fore is;

When I forgive or I am forgiven, what forgiveness does?

From Paul's words in Ephesians 4:32 and Ephesians 5:2-3, there are two things;

1. Forgiveness comforts the other person. Comfort is to help, to bring succor.
2. It confirms your love.

Recall the explanation of the writer of the book of Hebrews in Hebrews 8:12 and Hebrews 10:17...their sins and iniquities I will remember no more.

The phrase "remember no more" means you are not to record/ take account of it. It does not mean a loss of memory but there will be no reference to it, acting on it, and relating with it. Therefore, a remembrance of wrongs always wrecks relationships. We must learn to forget the past, and let it go completely. When we forgive, we grant right standing, we do not take record of it anymore. That means we will discipline our speech; we will not talk about it when talking to the person and when talking to others.

As we forgive, we have temperance, self-control, longsuffering, goodness, love, peace, meekness. They all work together in forgiveness.

What hinders people from forgiving is Selfishness, where it is about cravings, desire, just to satisfy self. Anger and bitterness are all about self.

When in the Spirit, it is about Jesus.

Peter's words about Christ's example, in his first letter speaks volume.

1 Peter 2:21-23 For even hereunto were ye called: because Christ also suffered for us, leaving us an example, that ye should follow his steps: Vs 22 Who did no sin, neither was guile found in his mouth: Vs 23 Who, when he was reviled, reviled not again; when he suffered, he threatened not, but committed himself to him that judgeth righteously:

Notice that he did not repay evil for evil, he did not try to revenge. We are in this world but not of this world, thus we have a duty to not to follow its manner and lifestyle, rather we follow Christ's example.

Paul corrected the conduct of some believers in Corinth, who took themselves to court before unbelievers.

1st Corinthians 6:7 now therefore there is utterly a fault among you, because ye go to law one with another, why do ye not rather take wrong? Why do ye not suffer yourselves to be defrauded?

It means you can be treated badly, cheated, by a fellow believer. Just like Christ, we would not retaliate, take a pound of flesh or make attempts to get even. Rather, we would choose to walk in love towards that believer.

Confession: It is in my nature to forgive, my nature in Christ Jesus, is love. I walk in forgiveness, and I refuse to retain any hurt, bitterness, unforgiveness and malice in my heart..

DAY 30

GIVING

One of the ways to be committed in a local church is to give

There is an act of giving where you give as occasion permits and there is a culture of giving. When you say culture, it is a part of the people. If you take away the culture of a race or a people, then you take away their uniqueness.

Christianity has a culture of giving.

Giving is to honour, to respect and express faith in God. When you give, it is to honour God.

The Bible is replete with so many examples and teachings on giving.

John 3:16 For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.

Whatever you love is what you give to.

Romans 8:32 He that spared not his own Son, but delivered him up for us all, how shall he not with him also freely give us all things?

He gave his son so that we can display the same character in/of giving

1st John 3:16 Hereby perceive we the love of God, because he laid

2nd Corinthians 8:3 For to their power, I bear record, yea, and beyond their power they were willing of themselves;

They gave according to their ability and beyond their ability, and they gave it willingly.

Vs 4 Praying us with much intreaty that we would receive the gift, and take upon us the fellowship of the ministering to the saints.

The immediate context of this is that the church in Jerusalem had needs as they were gathering support from all the churches in Asia to support the church in Jerusalem. Hence, the context here is to meet the needs of the church. The church had needs, they were giving material things to the needs of the church.

Observe,

Vs 5 And this they did, not as we hoped, but first gave their own selves to the Lord, and unto us by the will of God.

The fundamental foundation of giving is first of all, consecration. When you are not consecrated to God and the service of God, giving becomes a burden. Consecration implies giving yourself to Jesus. Giving should never be a burden on the believer as one cannot claim to be given to the Lord and not give to the church.

Giving is a culture of those who are consecrated to the service of God.

Confession: I am consecrated to God and the service of God, giving is not a burden to me. Giving is my culture. I give to meet the needs of the church, believers, and the furtherance of the gospel.